Kenneth Njeru

Why entrepreneurship holds the key to lasting prosperity for Kenya

Voices: Page 17

Interview

Anne Waiguru: My public service journey isn't ending in 2027

Big Read: Pg 14-15

FRESH, INDEPENDENT, DIFFERENT

NO. 5611
MONDAY, DECEMBER 22, 2025
www.the-star.co.ke

Ksh60/00 (Tsh 1,000 | Ush 2,000)

the STAR

As households, businesses complain, government paints a good year

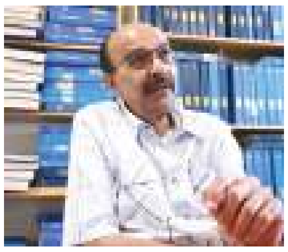
ALL I WANT FOR XMAS: JOBS AND MONEY AFTER FACING A TOUGH YEAR

Story on 4-5

STRANDED: Passengers wait for vehicles at the North Rift Shuttle station in Nairobi yesterday. Passengers traveling to various parts of the country wait for buses at Mwembe Tayari bus stage in Mombasa county on Saturday. Public Service Vehicles at Machakos country bus station
/ENOS TECHE /JOHN CHESOLI

Bountiful Christmas for NSE investors led by banking stocks

PAGE 3



Kiran Shah: From humble beginnings to building regional transport firm

PAGE 6

SEVERE INJURIES

Cops trace Jirongo's last movements, visit hotel

More than 10 people have so far been questioned, but no arrests made

Former Lugari MP Cyrus Jirongo /FILE

CYRUS OMBATI
@CyrusOmbati

DETECTIVES investigating the death of former Lugari MP Cyrus Jirongo visited a popular bar and restaurant along Magadi Road in Nairobi.

The team said they had traced him to the establishment, where he visited hours before he was involved in an accident kilometres away.

They interrogated staff at the venue on Saturday as part of efforts to trace the people he met before he died.

It is believed Jirongo left a restaurant in Karen before driving towards Langata Road and later joined Magadi Road to the hotel, where he stayed for a short while and drove off. Three hours later, he was involved in an accident.

Detectives sought to know who he was with, for how long, what he ate or drank and what he said.

The team is also recording statements from individuals he interacted with on the night in question, notably those present during a meeting at Karen Oasis Bar and Restaurant, Nairobi.

More than 10 people have so far been questioned, but no arrest made.

The hotel management refused to comment on the matter.

Jirongo's death following a road accident on December 13, continues to draw reactions, with some of his family members demanding a probe into the same.

He died from blunt force trauma that caused severe injuries to the chest and abdomen, a postmortem conducted on the body showed.

The postmortem also revealed he had injuries to the spine and legs.

The family pathologist Joseph Ndung'u and chief government pathologist Dr Johansen Oduor were present at the Lee Funeral Home when the exercise was conducted.

Dr Ndung'u said Jirongo's body had multiple injuries caused by blunt trauma. The body had two fractures on the right hand and fractures on the legs.

"There was a crash injury to the chest with multiple ribs fracture, perforation of the heart with rapture of the major vessels that connect the heart. There was also bleeding to the chest cavity," he said.

The body had crush injuries to the abdomen and liver, leading to bleeding in the abdominal cavity.

There was transection of the spinal cord [a tear within the spinal cord caused by traumatic injury], he added.

"We formed an opinion that he died as a result of crush injuries to the chest, abdomen and spinal injuries due to blunt force trauma," he said.

The results provided police with the way forward in the ongoing probe into the incident.

The DCI said on Tuesday it commenced investigations into the circumstances surrounding the death of Jirongo, who succumbed to injuries sustained in the fatal road accident at Karai, along the Nakuru-Nairobi Highway.

Preliminary investigations reveal that the accident involved Jirongo's motor vehicle and a public service vehicle bus belonging to Climax Company Limited.

The collision occurred at approximately 02:19 am, resulting in a head-on impact that pushed the deceased's vehicle about 25 metres from the point of impact, while the PSV bus came to a stop approximately 50 metres away.

In line with its mandate, the DCI deployed a combined team of homicide detectives and forensic experts from the National Forensic Laboratory, who visited the scene, conducted preliminary examinations and secured key exhibits.

During scene documentation, detectives recovered CCTV footage from Eagol Petrol Station, which has been subjected to initial review and analysis.

The footage shows that at 02:18:40 am the deceased drove into the petrol station from the Nairobi direction but did not fuel.

At 02:19:10 am, his vehicle stopped at the station's exit and, at 02:19:19 am, made a right turn, driving back towards the Nairobi direction. At 02:19:25 am, the CCTV captured the PSV bus ramming into the deceased's vehicle.

Detectives have interrogated the PSV driver, Tyrus Githinji, who had recorded a statement at the Naivasha Traffic Base.

Githinji is out on cash bail pending further investigations into the offence of causing death by dangerous driving.

He is required to report to the Naivasha Traffic Base on December 22, for further police action.

Additionally, detectives have interviewed the petrol station's night guard and fuel attendant, both of whom have provided their personal accounts of the events that occurred on the fateful night.

Further analysis of the CCTV footage is underway and additional statements will be recorded from passengers aboard the Climax Company bus and other witnesses.

JOSEPH NDUNG'U

We formed an opinion that he died as a result of crash injuries

STAR SURVEY

TODAY'S QUESTION

Will on the spot traffic offence fines enhance road discipline over the festive season?

YESTERDAY'S QUESTION

Will you be travelling during the festive season?

YES 54%

NO 46%

DIGITAL VOTING

Diaspora Kenyans demand inclusion in 2027 election

ALLAN KISIA

KENYANS living abroad have petitioned the government to procure a secure online diaspora voter registration system and guarantee their full participation in the 2027 general elections.

They warned that failure to act will perpetuate the long-standing disenfranchisement of citizens living outside the country.

The proposal was presented to special adviser to the President Jaoko Odinga by the Kenyan diaspora in Canada, during a Kenyan flag-raising ceremony held in Brampton City Hall in Ontario.

The meeting brought together political and diplomatic leaders, including Brampton mayor Patrick Brown, Kenya High Commissioner to Canada Ambassador Carolyne Daudi, Ontario Member of provincial parliament Mohamed Firin, Brampton city councillors Paul Vicente and Gurpartap Toor and officials from the Kenyan Canadian Association (KCA) led by its president and executive director, Ephraim Mwaura.

Mwaura underscored the political and economic significance of Kenyans living abroad, noting that the diaspora commands over one million potential votes, making it a decisive electoral force whose engagement can no longer be overlooked.

"Meaningful participation by Kenyans abroad will only be realised when they are genuinely represented across the country's social, economic, and political landscape," Mwaura said.

Despite constitutional guarantees, diaspora voting remains severely constrained. In the 2022 polls, only 10,444 diaspora voters participated globally and their engagement was limited solely to the presidential ballot.

In Canada and the United States, voting was restricted to just three polling stations each, located at embassies and consulates, locking out tens of thousands of eligible voters spread across vast geographical areas.

The proposal warns that without urgent legislative intervention, Kenyan diaspora communities risk another cycle of exclusion in 2027.

It calls on Parliament to amend the Elections Act and empower the Independent Electoral and Boundaries Commission to conduct a pilot programme followed by a full rollout of secure online voter registration and voting ahead of the next general elections.

Central to the proposal is the adoption of secure digital voting platforms leveraging blockchain technology, drawing inspiration from successful global models in Estonia, Switzerland and India.

The system would enable remote participation in all elective positions, including proposed diaspora parliamentary seats.

Proponents argue that blockchain-based voting offers end-to-end verifiability, immutable audit trails and significantly reduced operational costs compared to manual overseas voting.

The proposal cites Estonia's experience, where 51 per cent of votes in the 2023 parliamentary elections were cast online, as proof that secure, scalable and affordable digital voting is achievable.

Switzerland's verifiable e-voting trials and India's blockchain pilot projects are also highlighted as evidence that such systems can work for large, dispersed electorates like Kenya's diaspora.

Brampton mayor Patrick Brown gifts Ambassador Carolyne Daudi. They are flanked by special advisor Jaoko Odinga (L), Brampton officials and KCA's Ephraim Mwaura (2nd right) /HANDOUT

GLAD TIDINGS

Bountiful Christmas for investors at NSE

The Nairobi bourse staged one of the biggest rallies in over a decade

VICTOR AMADALA
@ItsAmadala

IT is a bountiful Christmas for investors at the Nairobi Securities Exchange following an easy ride in 2025 in which stocks, especially in the banking and manufacturing sectors, gained more than 200 per cent.

This year, the Nairobi bourse staged one of the most powerful rallies in more than a decade, as investor wealth soared by more than Sh1 trillion.

The Capital Markets Authority (CMA), said total market capitalisation has catapulted from Sh1.94 trillion in January to Sh2.9 trillion as of December 19, a 53 per cent gain signalling a robust recovery from two consecutive years of steep losses.

Data from the regulator shows the NSE All Share Index (NASI) recorded 52.5 per cent year to date (YTD), its strongest performance since its 2008 launch. The NSE 20 Share Index gained a substantial 55 per cent, tracking its best year since 2003. NSE 25 and NSE 10 indices are up 46 per cent, with the NSE 10 trading at record highs since its 2023 inception.

On Friday, the NASI, NSE 25 and NSE 20 share price indices increased by 3.48 per cent, 5.15 per cent and 3.93 per cent, respectively.

Market capitalisation increased by four per cent, pushing up investors' paper wealth by nearly Sh200 billion compared to the previous week.

Equity turnover and total shares traded decreased by 33.38 per cent and 45.82 per cent, respectively.

Co-operative Bank on Haile Selassie Avenue /FILE

The financial sector held steady at the lead, with banks dominating the top gainers list on Friday.

Cooperative Bank's share price gained a further 1.53 per cent on Friday, making it the seventh most traded stock on the NSE over the past three months.

It started the year with a share price of Sh16.45 and has since gained 41.3 per cent on that price valuation, ranking it 31st on the NSE in terms of year-to-date performance.

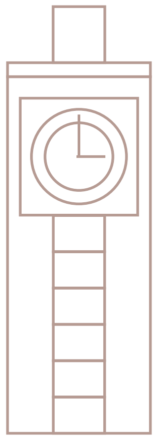
Equity Bank and Housing Finance stocks also gained the most during the week. Equity gained 1.6 per cent to close the week at Sh62.50. It began the year with a share price of Sh48.30 and has since gained 29.4 per cent on that price valuation, ranking it 36th on the NSE in terms of year-to-date performance.

Housing Finance, on the other hand, gained 120 per cent on that price valuation, ranking it 11th on the NSE in terms of year-to-date performance.

Overall, the Nairobi Securities Exchange Limited is the biggest gainer, having accrued 241 per cent in value in the past 342 days, followed by Home Afrika at 200 per cent and Kenya Re at 134 per cent. Investors in East Africa Portland Cement, Bamburi Cement and East Africa Breweries Limited have also pocketed premium rewards, propelled by acquisition deals.

CARTOON

CORRIDORS OF POWER



POLITICAL GOSSIP

Who is doing what and where in the world of politics

★ **WHISPERS IN THE** corridors of power suggest a once-ambitious MP has quietly changed political tacK ahead of the 2027 general election. After months of hinting at a bold governor bid, the man is now preparing to defend his seat, insiders say. The shift reportedly followed sobering signals from party headquarters that a different heavyweight had become the preferred candidate for the top county seat. Either way, the MP is suddenly pledging loyalty and insisting his heart was always with his constituency.

★ **A GOVERNOR ASPIRANT** from Western Kenya is supposedly reconsidering his 'strategy and political investments' amid the realisation that his godfather's fortunes are waning in the region. The aspirant, allegedly known for his deep pockets, has seemingly heavily invested in the godfather, hoping to ride on his popularity and influence to win the seat. However, the reality is fast changing with the ground support moving towards the opponent. The aspirant is now said to be purportedly reconsidering his strategy and could soon decamp and leave the man who has for decades been seen as the political heavyweight of the region.

★ **A HIGH-RANKING PARASTATAL** chief is a man supposedly under siege. Word has it that the man is allegedly on the verge of losing the high-profile job over links to the United Opposition. The man, who was reportedly handed the job through a former senior government official, is being accused of divided loyalty; he has been giving the former state official financial support. Whether real or perceived, that divided loyalty is likely to cost the man the lucrative role.

★ **A FORMER CABINET** minister might be struggling to figure out his future in politics. The politico, who for all intents and purposes sees himself as a consequential politician, is evidently struggling to figure out his next move, with the previous two moves failing before rollout. With the governor race in his backyard seeming out of his reach, the man is back to the drawing board.

If you have any tips send them to Tips@the-star.co.ke

NEWS

DIFFERENT SCRIPTS AS HOUSEHOLDS AND BUSINESSES COMPLAIN OF TOUGHER TIMES, THE

Kenyans travelling to various parts of the country wait for buses at Mwembe Tayari in Mombasa county on December 20 /JOHN CHESOLI

All I want this Christmas: Kenyans ask Santa for jobs and cash after a tough year

VICTOR AMADALA
@ItsAmadala

It is 7 am in Nairobi Central Business District. Joel Obare and his family of four have joined thousands of travellers in a rush for a last-minute bus ticket to get to upcountry for Christmas celebrations.

"I just want to get to my home in Kitale. A ticket costs Sh2,500. I need at least Sh12,000 to get my family there. That is more than a quarter of my monthly salary. Naenda kupiga nduru moja safi. 2025 imenionyesha vumbi (I just want to go cry my heart out. It has been a tough year)," Obare tells this writer as he finds a space in the queue.

"Taxes and other statutory deductions saw my take-home drop from Sh56,000 to Sh46,000. Rent went up by Sh1,500. Unusual salary delays pushed me into borrowing from friends, local shops, a gas supplier and digital loans, among others. It has been a crazy year. I thank God this far."

Obare's wife, Jennifar, says that she lost count of the number of times her family slept on empty stomachs. Although food prices were moderately fair compared to 2024, finding that coin was an issue this year. "I hope 2026 will be better," she says.

While Joy Mirembo got her first job as a receptionist at a city hotel, her brother Laban Mirembo lost his job of 12 years at a local non-profit entity.

"I have gone to 12 job interviews since August this year. None has yielded. I once attended a job interview for a nightclub manager along Thika Road. Thousands of graduates showed up, some with Master's degrees."

Duncan Mwirigi, the founder of Rims Motors, is only hoping for a better new year.

"The business environment was tough. I made the lowest sales since 2020. The tax component was also an issue. Fortunately, the steady shilling and more affordable loans sustained many of us in the import business," he said.

As households and businesses complain of tougher times, the government paints 2025 as a good year, characterised by lower cost of living, steady currency, reduced borrowing rates, lower fuel prices and good agricultural yield.

In his third National address in November, President William Ruto reminded the National Assembly of how the previous government was forced to turn to costly and unsustainable subsidies to save Kenyans from the high cost of basic commodities as inflation hit near double-digit.

According to him, the cost of basic household commodities has dropped significantly, with a two-kg packet of maize flour currently retailing below Sh150, down from a high of Sh200 before his government took power.

> *Under the new framework, all privatisation proceeds will be ring-fenced and invested strictly in public infrastructure projects that generate and preserve long-term value*

He hailed his government's sound forex policies that have seen the shilling held stable at Sh129 against the US dollar for the past two years, easing both the cost of doing business for importers while passing the gains to consumers.

He also highlighted policies like subsidised fertiliser and seed for higher agricultural yields, with data showing that the country is set for a historic maize harvest of 70 million (90kg) bags in 2025, up from 67 million in 2024 and more than double the 34.3 million bags recorded in 2022.

The number of Kenyans facing food shortages and malnutrition is projected to rise to 2.1 million by January 2026, bumper harvest reported by the government notwithstanding.

The latest Agra Foundation Food Security Monitor report shows the rising number of hungry people is driven by poor rainfall, rising food prices and resource-based conflicts.

The report shows that about 1.8 million people are currently experiencing hunger, mostly in the arid and semi-arid lands, where families continue to struggle with limited access to food and water.

Agra notes that while inflation has stabilised and some commodities

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GOVERNMENT PAINTS 2025 AS A GOOD YEAR

Maize flour at Quickmart Thome in Marurui /FILE

have become cheaper, food remains costly for many households.

"Maize prices fell by 3.63 per cent month-on-month and 13.48 per cent over three months, supported by ongoing harvests, though prices remain 16.06 per cent higher year-on-year," the report shows. "This reflects structural market inefficiencies and localised production challenges."

Even so, various economic surveys and data show that Kenya's economy was more resilient.

According to the World Bank, several macroeconomic indicators continue to show strength with inflation within target, a stable exchange rate and foreign exchange reserves at record highs.

"Many key macroeconomic indicators continue to show strength; however, the fiscal outlook remains subject to downside risks that could threaten sustained and inclusive economic growth," said Jorge Tudela Pye, World Bank country Economist for Kenya.

The bank projects Kenya's economy to grow by an average 4.9 per cent between 2025 and 2027, an increase from the previous estimate.

However, fiscal pressures are intensifying, with the FY2024-25 deficit widening to 5.9 per cent of GDP—above the original 4.3 per cent target—driven mostly by revenue shortfalls and increasingly rigid expenditure structures. Risks of fiscal slippage persist.

The International Monetary Fund, on the other hand, projects Kenya's economy to expand by 4.8 per cent in 2025 and 4.9 per cent in 2026, a slight improvement from the 4.7 per cent growth recorded in 2024.

The Bretton Woods Institute says this is supported by macroeconomic stabilisation and reform efforts.

Data from the Kenya National Bureau of Statistics shows Kenya's economy grew by five per cent in the second quarter of 2025, up from 4.6 per cent in the same period last year. The growth was driven by agriculture, forestry and fishing (4.4 per cent), transport and storage (5.4 per cent) and financial and insurance services (6.6 per cent).

Economic analysts agree that Kenya's economy withstood various volatilities in 2025 and hope for better 2026.

Some are, however, cautious of growing political tension in the country, East Africa and ongoing conflicts in the global space.

Richard Ngereso, an economic consultant at Global Connect, cites mid-year anti-government protests, erratic rainfall and a drastic pause in international aid as top hindrances to economic progression in 2025.

"Most businesses were interrupted, poor rainfall sparked food inflation and many people lost jobs due to harsh trade, immigration and aid policies by President Donald Trump. I hope for a more liquid 2026 as politicians repatriate cash back into the country in readiness for the 2027 elections. Government is expected to spend more on infrastructure," Ngereso said.

His sentiments are shared by Nelly Wayua, who hopes that the government will come up with policies that favour businesses and those at the bottom of the economic pyramid.

"Singapore here we come," she jokes, alluding to President Ruto's dream to propel Kenya into a developed economy.

"The transformative monetary policy review, if supported by sound agricultural policies, infrastructure upgrade and digital innovations, will make a good 2026. I pray for less volatility in the global marketplace."

Chief executives of top firms in Kenya are also hoping for a better year.

The Central Bank's November survey shows that 43 per cent are very optimistic about economic growth in 2026 compared to 2025.

Forty per cent are expecting the expansion to stagnate, with 16.7 per cent expecting it to worsen in the coming year.

Speaking at the post-Monetary Policy Committee press briefing, the Central Bank of Kenya governor Kamau Thugge said the optimism has been rising in the past months, driven by easing loan rates and a stable foreign exchange regime.

"The optimism was attributed to resilient agricultural production supported by favourable weather conditions, the stable macroeconomic environment with low inflation and stable exchange rate, declining interest rates and improved private sector credit growth," Thugge said.

The positivity is reflected by the growth of activities in the private sector, which touched a five-year high in November on ease of borrowing, granting traders access to cheap loans, while a stable shilling lowered import costs.

The Purchasing Managers' Index hit 55 in November, up from 52.5 in October and the highest since October 2020.

Readings above 50 signal an improvement in business conditions from the previous month, while readings below 50 show deterioration.

Joseph Muge, a shopkeeper in Zambezi, Kiambu county, says optimism indices and rosy surveys by the state and international agencies mean nothing if the ordinary Kenyan has no money in the pocket.

He only has one wish this Christmas: "Money circulates in the economy in 2026 so that I can afford food, education, health and shelter for my family."

President William Ruto during the 12th National and County Governments Coordinating Summit at State House, Nairobi, on December 10 /PCS

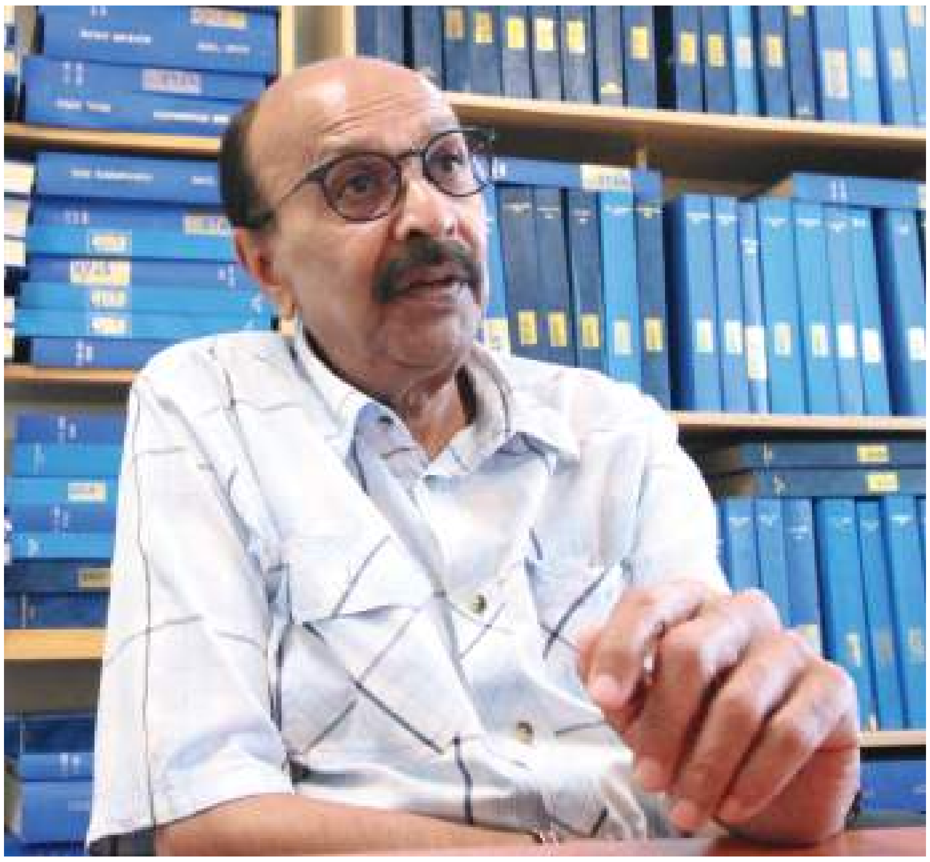
NEWS BUSINESS

BIG INTERVIEW

From humble start to building a regional transport company

Service to community saw Kiran Shah given the EBS honour by President William Ruto

MARTIN MWITA
@MwitaMartin



Kiran "Kiru" Shah during an interview at The Star Newspaper offices on December 19, 2025 /ENOS TECHE

KIRAN Shah famously known as "Kiru" has been in the country's transport and logistics industry for decades, running Swan Carriers Limited, a family-owned transport company which operates in Kenya and beyond borders, serving key sectors of the economy. He has also over the years played an instrumental role in disaster response across Kenya. He has transformed his business into a vehicle for national service.

His compassion and enduring service to the nation and community saw him conferred with the prestigious Elder of the Order of the Burning Spear (E.B.S) during the recent Jamhuri Day cellebrations by President William Ruto. The Star spoke to Kiru on his personal journey, business and service to community.

Who is Kiran "Kiru" Shah, where was he born, education and his beginnings in business?

I was born in Kisumu in 1959. Our family has been in existence in Kisumu for the last 90 years. I went to Aga Khan Primary School then Kisumu Boys and after my basic O-Levels, I found my way to the UK. My dad sent me to study but I didn't study and instead, I started working. I opened a small grocery shop with a partner from the UK. After two years, I was called back home, there was a lot of work within the family businesses. My father had four siblings so it was a large business and we were all involved. That time we were into confectionary, milling and also transport.

As our family grew bigger, we started going different ways and eventually now me and my two boys. I shifted to Nairobi in 1985. I was the first one to move to the capital and since then I have settled in Nairobi but I still have a home in Kisumu.

Tell us about Swan Carriers? When and how did start?

Swan Carriers Ltd is a logistics and transport solutions company dedicated to providing reliable, efficient and customer-focused services. We specialise in the movement of goods across diverse sectors, ensuring timely delivery and operational excellence. Our business is built on strong values of integrity, innovation and sustainability and we pride ourselves on being a trusted partner to both local and regional clients. It was started in 1980 with three small trucks, 10-tonne canters.

Today, Swan Carriers has 240 trucks majority of them trailers and has created more than 436 direct jobs and hundreds of indirect jobs. The headquarters shifted to Athi River from Kisumu.

What are some of the challenges you faced during the early stages of Swan and today?

Before there were no challenges. Drivers were good, people were honest, and roads were not congested so business was flowing and the turnaround was quick. Today as we speak, there are lots of challenges. The traffic on the roads, competition, people want to become millionaires overnight. Along the corridors we get challenges at the borders, for instance there is 18 kilometer line at the Malaba border because systems are not working properly so clearance and crossing becomes a challenge. These delays add to operating costs. We were doing up to five trips a month now were are down to two to three trips. There are non-tariff barriers along the corridors which are a challenge. If we were to follow the law and put into good use the infrastructure and technology we have, hopefully things will be better.

How would you describe your leadership style and what drives you?

Approachable, listening and patience. As a transporter, you have to be patient and someone who listens. If you are a hot tempered person then transport is not good business for you.

How do you balance family and running a successful business?

I have two boys and they all are into the business, both the wives are working, grandchildren. We have our day-offs where we just spend time together especially Sundays is just family, we sit, have food together and just relax.

Do you have any family values that you have incorporated into the business?

Yes. Honesty is the first one. Whatever you do, do it with honesty. Respect is another thing and then dignity.

Is Swan Carriers exploring any new technologies to improve operations?

Yes. We are looking into Electric Vehicles (EVs) in the near future. We have and continue to automate our systems for smooth operations and other changes.

What does it take to build a strong family-owned business?

First of all is trust. Then cooperation within the family and professionalism. Family life should be separated from the business and have a continuity plan. The business should operate within a constitution then there will be no 'matata' (worries).

> *Family life should be separated from the business and have a continuity plan. The business should operate within a constitution then there will be no 'matata'*

Where do you see Swan in the next five to ten years and probably as Kiru, what legacy do you want to leave behind?

Well, I would not say I want to become a number one transporter, but an efficient transporter with good values. In the year 2030, our milestone, Swan Carriers will be 50 years old. That obviously we want to see, we want to see Swan Carriers become a strong regional transporter. We want to become a multinational covering the East African region, the Southern African Development Community (SADC) and beyond. That is our vision.

Congratulations on the Elder of the Order of the Burning Spear (E.B.S) award. How does it feel and probably, what does it mean for you?

I never thought I would be recognised. It came as a surprise. When I got a call that I will be part of the team going to State House for the awards, I still could not believe and neither did I know what I was getting. When my name was called and I started walking towards His Excellency the President, my citation started being read then I heard E.B.S and that shocked me. I was expecting maybe a Moran of the Order of the Burning Spear (M.B.S.). I felt I was in a different world but ofcourse I was before the President so I behaved properly. But the joy, I can't explain. You know, at that time I wanted my phone to start sharing but the phones had been taken. People who were watching on TV took videos later and later on started posting. I don't have words to tell you what it means, but it means everything to me. Because the work, at least somebody recognised what we have done. Apart from being in the transport business, the community is at the core heart of our existence. Our contributions span humanitarian relief, public safety and organised community leadership. We have always transported relief food, medical supplies and essential goods free of charge to regions facing famine, drought, floods and other emergencies. We also mobilise resources which we ensure reach those in marginalised areas. For instance we recently brought together children living with Cerebral Palsy from Machakos County and had a Christmas party with them, gave out wheelchairs, transport. But all these things I don't do them for fame, just making sure that we try and build a society where everybody feels appreciated.

What motivated you to engage in philanthropic work in Kenya?

I have been fortunate and it is my way of contributing to Kenya's growth and helping those in need.

You are the Vice Chairman of the Visa Oshwal Community. Tell us about it?

The community is over 100 years in Kenya and our headquarters is at the Oshwal Centre in Nairobi.We have around 8,000 members, it is a clan and I am privileged to be the vice chair for two years now. Our basic philosophy is Jainism. This is an ancient Indian religion focused on spiritual purity, liberation and non-violence teaching that all living beings have a soul and deserve compassion, leading to strict vegetarianism and gentle living practices. We are 100 per cent vegetarian. We value others well-being. Cultural heritage is there, the Indian culture, the Shah cultural heritage, all is there. We foster unity.

What would you say is one of the most rewarding parts of your career?

Service to community. The business will be there because others are looking after it but service to humanity is the most rewarding thing to me.

Who are your role models growing up, what did you learn from them and how did you apply that into the business?

Okay, first role model is my parents, obviously. But if you look, Manu Chandaria, he has done quite a lot of philanthropic work. There are also many others doing things unannounced.

As an individual, how do you maintain the personal motivation, especially when you are faced with challenges, how do you stay calm?

We have a lot of problems in the community, the normal problems. As a leader when you listen to those problems, you feel that yours are nothing and the best thing is patience. You become a listener. Do not act without listening. It helps remaining calm.

Any parting shot?

Merry Christmas to the Christians and Happy New Year to all, as a transporter please exercise caution while on roads. Drive safe. Don't drink and drive. Life is very precious save your life from the road carnage.

NEWS BUSINESS

PHOTO STORY

Amsons Group Managing Director, Edha Nahdi and Sinoma CBMI Chairman, Zhang Sicai sign the $250 million Matuga Clinker Factory Construction contract, looking on is Bamburi Cement Plc Chairman John Simba, President William Ruto, Trade CS Lee Kinyanjui and Bamburi Cement Head of Legal and Company Secretary Joyce Munene /HANDOUT

LOAN PRESSURES

State spent 92% of taxes to pay debt in November

Debt servicing absorbed more than development and county transfers

JACKTONE LAWI
@jacktonelawi

National Treasury spent Sh159.92billion to pay debt in the month of November alone, making it the single largest call on government cash resources.

This was against a revenue collection of Sh173.5 billion for the same month, on paper out of the total November collections only Sh13.58 billion was left to run government operations.

The National Treasury's monthly update shows that public debt service topped all spending items and continued to exert pressure on the exchequer.

Despite an 8.2 per cent year on year increase in tax collection in November to Sh173.5 billion, due to improved compliance and stronger performance from income taxes and VAT, it was overshadowed by debt repayments.

"The funds were channeled towards servicing both domestic and external debt, including Treasury bills and bonds held by local banks and pension funds, as well as repayments to bilateral and multilateral lenders," said National Treasury CS John Mbadi in the statement of actual revenues for November.

Debt servicing absorbed more than the combined allocation for development expenditure and county transfers during the month, highlighting limited fiscal space for new projects.

Recurrent expenditure was the second-largest spending item, with Sh109.12 billion issued in November.

These funds were mainly disbursed to ministries, departments and agencies (MDAs) to cover salaries and allowances for public servants, operational costs, and transfers to constitutional offices and independent commissions.

County governments also featured prominently among the top recipients of exchequer issues.

The National Treasury released Sh35.54 billion as the equitable share allocation in November, funds that were distributed to the 47 county governments to finance devolved functions.

Development expenditure, by contrast, remained modest. The government issued Sh24.31 billion for development spending in November, directed towards infrastructure, housing, water, energy and ICT projects.

Treasury data shows that development absorption continues to lag behind targets, partly due to financing constraints and slower implementation of large capital projects.

Over the five months from July to November 2025, tax revenues reached Sh909.8 billion, representing a 6.2 per cent increase compared to the same period last year.

Non-tax revenues stood at Sh8.13 billion in November, while domestic borrowing remained the primary financing source, with Sh108.82 billion raised from the local market.

External loans and grants contributed a relatively small Sh5.63 billion, showing a trend that has seen Kenya's growing reliance on domestic debt to plug fiscal gaps.

Despite the increased Debt repayment Central Bank hold that the money market remained liquid during the week ending December 18, with open market operations remaining active.

"Commercial banks' excess reserves averaged Sh23.7 billion above the 3.25 percent Cash Reserve Ratio (CRR) requirement. The Kenya Shilling Overnight Interbank Average (KESONIA) rate declined marginally to 8.98 percent on December 18 from 9.02 percent on December 11," CBK said in its weekly brief

During the week, the average number of interbank transactions decreased to 14 from 28 in the previous week, while the average value traded also decreased to Sh11.3 billion from Sh16.1 billion.

Cabinet Secretary for the National Treasury John Mbadi /HANDOUT

By Kipkemoi Kibias

EXPERT OPINION

New Lessos power line to drive Kenya's industrial economy

Electricity is often spoken about in terms of megawatts,power lines and sub-stations. Yet for millions of Kenyans, its true value is felt not in technical terms, but in lives saved, businesses sustained, knowledge unlocked, and dignity restored. It is felt in the operating theatre when a life is saved without interruption. It is heard in the hum of a milk chiller preserving a farmer's produce and in a workshop where young people earn a living instead of drifting into despair.

The completion of the Lessos-Kabarnet Transmission Line by the Kenya Electricity Transmission Company (KETRACO) is a testament of the impact to be felt now that electricity has been extended in that region. This is not just an engineering milestone, it is a line that carries with it opportunity, and the promise of inclusive growth. It is a statement about the kind of development that thegovernment is undertaking: people-focused, inclusive, and built to last.

This project is a clear illustration of how strategic infrastructure underpins economic transformation, not in theory, but in lived reality. Theline stretches for about 65 kilometres, linking the 220/132kV Lessos sub-station in Nandi Hills to a newly constructed 132/33kV onein Kabarnet. Theline traverses Nandi, Uasin Gishu, Elgeyo Marakwet, and Baringo counties.

It does three strategic things simultaneously. First, it replaces the overstretched 33kV supply from Lessos with a robust high-voltage backbone, dramatically improving voltage quality and reducing outages. Second, it strengthens grid stability in the North and Central Rift.

Third, it prepares the region for the future, integrating seamlessly with the planned 132kV Kabarnet-Rumuruti Transmission Line, which will link this corridor to the Mt Kenya network and enable power flows from geothermal plants, the Seven Forks hydropower complex, and wind power from Loiyangalani.

In energy planning, foresight is critical. Transmission lines are not built for the presentalone; but for future generations as well. For residents of Baringo and its environs, stable power has long been more of anaspiration than reality.

Small and medium scale manufacturers have faced high operational costs that have limited their growth andopportunities for job creation. The arrival of reliable transmission infrastructure changes this equation fundamentally.

Nowhere is the human value of electricity clearer than in healthcare. For years, hospitals in Baringo and Elgeyo Marakwet counties operated under constant uncertainty, relying heavily on diesel generators. The cost has been high, the risks even higher.

With the new line, institutions such as Kabarnet County andKoibatek Sub-County Referral Hospitals, Marigat and MogotioSub-County Hospitals, Chemolingot Hospital in Tiaty, and Kabartonjo Hospital in Baringo North can now depend on a stable grid power. Operating theatres, maternity wards, nurseries for newborns, laboratories, imaging equipment, vaccine cold chains, and digital health systems can function reliably and affordably. When hospitals function efficiently, families avoid catastrophic health costs. This is development aligned with the Bottom-Up Economic Transformation Agenda. It is a clear expression of President William Ruto's vision of transforming Kenya into a modern, first-world industrial economy.

County-driven industrial initiatives -among them the Baringo Cha Coffee Mill; the Kerio Valley mango processing plant; Salawa cotton ginnery, Sabakia dairy cooperative, and the Mogotio Sisal Factory - can now operate uninterrupted to supply local, regional, and international markets. This is how rural economies industrialise. Small enterprises will be among the biggest winners. Barbershops, salons, welding workshops, schools, hotels, retail outlets, and otherbusinesses that could notafford diesel.

The writer is acting MD and CEO at KETRACO

BUSINESS PICTORIAL

Equity Bank managing director Moses Nyabanda with Quickmart Kamakis customers Faith Kamoshe and Nancy Koki, lucky winners of the Equity and Quickmart Lipa Bila Presha partnership **/HANDOUT**

Doud Mart account manager Enoch Abukuse, director Lucas Zhang and HR Maureen Chepkurui cut a ribbon during the official opening of its first Kenyan flagship store at Runda Mall on December 17 **/DOUGLAS OKIDDY**

Kingdom of the Netherlands Embassy official Jelmer Van Veen, World Waternet country director Peter de Koning, KCB Group CEO Paul Russo and corporate banking director John Okullo during the signing of an MoU between KCB Group and World Waternet at Kencom House **/HANDOUT**

Baobab Beach Resort & Spa food and beverage manager Charles Otieno, general manager Gabriel Kipsang, marketing executive Loise Karanja and entertainment manager Samwel Mbugua during the resort's Christmas tree lighting ceremony **/HANDOUT**

Kenya Film Commission director Collins Okoth, GIZ representative of film creative and industry Linda Musita and Kenya Film Commission board chairman Sudi Wandabusi with five winners of the Kenya Film Develeopment Grant **/ENOS TECHE**

Afristar staff members from Port Reitz station in Mombasa county during a pool volleyball session at Nyali Reef Hotel as part of the 2025 team-building organised by management **/HANDOUT**

Oryx Energies head of business James Ngugi (L) and Gasfil Kenya MD James Macharia at the newly launched Oryx petrol station in Eldoret. The station now offers LPG as a more affordable alternative fuel to petrol **/HANDOUT**

South Africa Haemophilia Foundation and Medical Scientific Advisory Council chairperson Yasmin Goga, WHO Kenya officer-in-charge Adiele Onyeze, haemophilia advocate Humphrey Haji, Ministry of Health's sickle cell and cardiovascular technical lead Dr Yvette Kisaka and NNHF advocacy, communications and strategic partnership senior manager Natasha Honan during the Novo Nordisk Haemophilia and Haemoglobinopathies Foundation launch at the Best Western Meridian Hotel in Nairobi **/LEAH MUKANGAI**

Elijah Sawe, CEO of Sakifarm Limited and Frankline Okata, acting chief enterprise business officer at Safaricom during the handing over of a Bajaj tricycle under the ongoing Shangwe @25 promotion **/HANDOUT**

NEWS GENERAL

Controller of Budget Margaret Nyakang'o during the National Tax Convention in Nairobi on November 27 /LEAH MUKANGAI

CHRONIC CASH CRUNCH

Contractor wars, court battles stall county projects

This is despite counties paying 90% of contract sums

JULIUS OTIENO
@JuliusOtieno04

A seeming deep-seated dispute with contractors, protracted court battles and chronic cash crunches are stalling development projects across counties.

The end result is billions of shillings of public funds locked in unfinished projects

Details contained in the latest County Governments Budget Implementation Review Report by Controller of Budget Margaret Nyakang'o show that dozens of projects—some initiated at the onset of devolution—have stalled.

This is despite counties paying contractors up to 90 per cent of the contract sums, in some cases.

The report paints a grim picture of "white elephant" projects spread across the country, where public resources continue to sink into idle sites while essential services remain undelivered.

In many instances, counties and contractors are locked in bitter disputes over alleged non-payment, breach of contract and project variations.

Counties accuse contractors of abandoning sites, while contractors counter-accuse devolved units of failing to honour payment schedules.

In other cases, counties are battling lawsuits filed by contractors whose contracts were terminated or by firms that lost out during procurement.

Some devolved units also cite lack of funds, delayed exchequer disbursements, and failure by the National Treasury to release conditional grants as key reasons for stalled works.

The CoB further notes that political transitions have worsened the situation, with some county administrations deliberately abandoning projects initiated by their predecessors.

Insecurity in parts of the country and weak due diligence during procurement—resulting in engagement of contractors without adequate technical or financial capacity—have compounded the problem.

Machakos county is among the hardest hit.

The report shows that 54 development projects valued at Sh1.13 billion have stalled, even though Sh314.26 million has already been paid to contractors. Only six of the stalled projects have so far been revived.

"The first three projects were initiated before devolution; therefore, the contract or procurement files cannot be traced and no estimated value is available for these projects," the report shows.

Among the stalled works are the construction of Machawood offices at Machawood Studios in Mikuyu/Vota Village (Sh39.74 million), a commercial mixed-use development comprising two 50-metre blocks with a walkway boulevard between them (Sh55.49 million), and a 12-storey office block valued at Sh394.99 million.

The county blamed contractor non-performance and abandonment of sites.

(+) INSTANT ANALYSIS

Overall, the CoB warns that unless counties strengthen procurement due diligence, improve cash-flow planning, resolve disputes promptly and insulate development priorities from political transitions, stalled projects will continue to drain public resources.

THE END RESULT IS BILLIONS OF SHILLINGS OF PUBLIC FUNDS LOCKED IN UNFINISHED PROJECTS

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- A bachelor's degree in accounting, Finance, Business Administration, Law or a related field.
- Professional certifications such as Certified Internal Auditor (CIA), Certified Public Accountant (CPA), Certified Compliance & Ethics Professional (CCEP), or similar credentials is preferred.
- Strong understanding of regulatory compliance requirements and standards

All applications should be submitted through the link on or before 4th January 2026; ***https://www.myjobsinkenya.com/jobs/compliance-officer-2/view***

SALES & MARKETING OFFICER - MY JOBS IN KENYA CLIENT

Our client, RAKAAB TECH is Africa's leading digital ticketing & fleet management platform. As a leading technology company in the transportation industry, Rakaab Tech is committed to transforming how transportation services are delivered across Africa. With over a decade of experience, they specialize in providing cutting-edge solutions that make operations more efficient, reduce costs, and enhance transparency. Their innovative approach has empowered their clients to save time, eliminate corruption, and streamline their business processes.

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All applications should be submitted through the link on or before 4th January 2026; ***https://www.myjobsinkenya.com/jobs/sales-marketing-officer/view***

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- Minimum 4–8 years of experience in joinery or furniture manufacturing, with at least 2–3 years in a supervisory or in-charge role.
- Strong understanding of joinery techniques, carpentry methods, furniture construction, and finishing processes.
- Proficient in reading and interpreting technical drawings and production documents.
- Hands-on knowledge of workshop machinery (CNC, panel saw, edge banding, sanding, etc.).

All applications should be submitted through the link on or before 30th December 2025; ***https://www.myjobsinkenya.com/jobs/joinery-furniture-production-in-charge/view***

INTERIOR DESIGNER OR ARCHITECT - MY JOBS IN KENYA CLIENT

We are a leading interior design and fit-out company known for delivering high-quality, innovative, and functional spaces across residential, commercial, hospitality, and retail sectors. We are looking for a creative and detail-oriented Interior Designer or Architect to join our dynamic team.

MINUMUM REQUIREMENTS

- Bachelor's degree in Interior Design, Architecture, or a related field.
- Approximately 2 years of experience with a reputable design, fit-out, or architectural firm.
- Strong proficiency in AutoCAD (2D essential; 3D is an advantage).
- Working knowledge of SketchUp, Revit, 3ds Max, Photoshop, or similar design software is a plus.

All applications should be submitted through the link on or before 30th December 2025; ***https://www.myjobsinkenya.com/jobs/interior-designer-or-architect/view***

MARKETING ASSISTANT - MY JOBS IN KENYA CLIENT

Our client in the FMCG industry is looking for a creative and detail-oriented Marketing Assistant to support the planning, execution, and monitoring of marketing initiatives. This role is ideal for someone eager to gain hands-on experience across various marketing functions.

MINIMUM REQUIREMNTS

- Certificate/Diploma in Marketing, Communications, Business, or related field
- 0–2 years of experience in a marketing-related role or internship.
- Strong written and verbal communication skills.
- Familiarity with digital marketing tools (e.g., Canva, Mailchimp, Google Analytics, Hootsuite) is a plus.
- Basic knowledge of social media platforms (LinkedIn, Instagram, Facebook, etc.).

All applications should be submitted through the link on or before 30th December 2025; ***https://www.myjobsinkenya.com/jobs/marketing-assistant-1/view***

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MINIMUM REQUIREMNTS

- Bachelors Degree
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- Strong Excel/Google Sheets skills (VLOOKUP, pivot tables, formulas)
- Experience using SaaS tools (scheduling, workflow, CRM)

All applications should be submitted through the link on or before 23rd December 2025; ***https://www.myjobsinkenya.com/jobs/service-coordinator-kenya-based-supporting-uk-operations/view***

BILINGUAL CUSTOMER SERVICE EXECUTIVE (ENGLISH, SPANISH AND /OR GERMAN) - MY JOBS IN KENYA CLIENT

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- Language Proficiency: Fluent in English, Spanish, and at least one additional European language (e.g., French, Italian, or German).
- A diploma or degree in a related field
- At least three years of experience in customer service
- Customer-Centric: Passionate about delivering an exceptional customer experience, ss

All applications should be submitted through the link on or before 23rd December 2025; ***https://www.myjobsinkenya.com/jobs/bilingual-customer-service-executive-english-spanish-and-or-german/view***

NEWS GENERAL


DCP leader Rigathi Gachagua at the party's event on December 3 /HANDOUT

DEFIANCE

Gachagua's expanding headache as Mt Kenya leaders align with Ruto

Over three-quarters of MPs remain in the President's camp

JULIUS OTIENO
@JuliusOtieno04

FORMER Deputy President and DCP leader Rigathi Gachagua is facing mounting challenges as more Mt Kenya political heavyweights boldly rally the region behind President William Ruto's re-election bid.

The latest to declare support for Ruto is Kirinyaga Governor Anne Waiguru, who has launched a high-profile mobilisation campaign aimed at consolidating the region's backing for the Kenya Kwanza government.

On Saturday, Waiguru addressed a gathering of 2,000 women, urging them to support Ruto and the government's development agenda.

She called on the region to reject opposition politics, stressing that the area cannot afford to be out of government for five years.

"The opposition cannot win the 2027 elections. They lack a clear strategy and agenda to move the country forward," she said.

Waiguru, together with other like-minded leaders, pledged to unite the region behind Ruto's second-term bid.

"We must align with the winning team. Tomorrow's journey is planned today. I will be in government and I am never on the losing side," she declared.

Her support for Ruto comes at a critical time as several regional leaders consolidate behind the incumbent, potentially undermining Gachagua's bid to strengthen his influence in Mt Kenya.

Over three-quarters of MPs from Mt Kenya remain in the President's camp despite Gachagua's rigorous campaign to have them disciplined by voters in 2027.

Two MPs who were initially supporting Gachagua— Gathoni Wamuchomba (Githunguri) and Mary Wamaua (Maragua)—have abandoned him.

Gachagua has positioned himself as the region's political supremo, vowing to use the region to ensure Ruto serves only one term as President.

However, the apparent defiance of several leaders and their vow to support Ruto now threatens his dominance in the region.

Former President Uhuru Kenyatta's Jubilee Party, though yet to officially endorse Ruto, has been at the centre of Gachagua's criticism for allegedly threatening his dominance.

Meanwhile, former Trade CS Moses Kuria, through his Chama Cha Kazi (CCK) party and Mwangi Kiunjuri's Service Party, have also been influencing the region's political dynamics.

Kuria, who had initially hinted at a presidential run in 2027, recently suggested he might contest for Nairobi Governor instead.

His involvement in the recently concluded Mbeere North parliamentary by-election drew attention after opposition leaders accused his party of splitting votes, thereby enabling UDA's victory.

Kuria defended his party, noting that his candidate, Duncan Mbu, garnered 2,480 votes. In the race, UDA beat the DP's candidate by around 500 votes. He argued that opposition figures campaigned against his candidate, making claims of vote division misleading.

Analysts note that the opposition's recent loss in Mbeere North strengthened the government side's resolve.

"Mbeere North complicates matters for Gachagua," political analyst Martin Andati observed.

"The loss gives leaders on the government side hope that they have a fighting chance and undermines the former DP's claim to unchallenged dominance in the region."

(+) INSTANT ANALYSIS

The shifting political dynamics in Mt Kenya underscore that loyalty to Gachagua is no longer guaranteed. Each legislator's decision will have implications for their political future and could ultimately shape the outcome of the 2027 election. The region's alignment appears increasingly tipped toward Ruto, signalling that the former DP's path to consolidating Mt Kenya support is fraught with challenges.

HOST COUNTRY AGREEMENT

No external pressure in granting NGO immunity, says Foreign Affairs PS

ELIUD KIBII

THE Ministry of Foreign and Diaspora Affairs has denied claims that the government was influenced by external political pressure in granting diplomatic privileges and immunities to the Global Centre on Adaptation amid public uproar.

Principal Secretary Korir Sing'Oei, in a statement on Saturday, dismissed the claims that the Host Country Agreement between Kenya and the GCA—an international organisation promoting climate change adaptation solutions—was the result of lobbying or undue foreign influence as claimed in sections of the media.

"The imputation that the Host Country Agreement to the Global Centre on Adaptation was granted as a result of external political pressure is without any foundation," Sing'Oei said.

He noted that the process of granting the status followed all legal procedures under the Privileges and Immunities Act, which empowers the ministry to negotiate and conclude such agreements with intergovernmental and international organisations operating in the country.

The privileges and immunities include protection from suit and legal process in respect of performance of official duties, exemption from direct taxes upon emoluments received as an officer or servant of the organisation, immunity from national service obligations, immigration restrictions and alien registration in respect of officers and servants and their spouses and dependent relatives.

They will also enjoy privileges in respect of exchange control facilities and exemption from tax or duty on the importation of furniture, personal property and household effects of an officer or servant first arriving to take up a post in Kenya.

According to the statement, the ministry received a formal request from GCA on July 27, 2023, seeking Host Country Agreement status to facilitate the establishment and operation of its regional office in Nairobi.

The office is part of GCA's global network headquartered in Rotterdam, Netherlands and supports Africa's climate diplomacy and resilience-building agenda.

GCA was founded by Prof Patrick Verkooijen, who was appointed by President William Ruto as the Chancellor of the University of Nairobi in January 2024. Assuming his role in February 2024, he became the first foreign chancellor of a public university in Kenya.

While the appointment drew criticism and opposition from a section of Kenyans, Ruto said Verkooijen had a proven track record in many domains, particularly in adaptation and other climate action initiatives in Africa.

The President was also present during the ground-breaking of GCA's offices in Nairobi in July 2024. Given the climate crisis is real, the centre would help harness expertise and bring policy makers and development actors into the space, Ruto said during the event.

The global NGO has, however, faced controversies primarily concerning its funding, leadership, and relationships. Accusations include exaggerating its role in projects to secure donations and a perceived conflict of interest involving its CEO and his relationship with Ruto, according to Dutch media.

This has raised concerns domestically, with a section of Kenyans and lawyers demanding that the host country deal be made public. After the ministry declined to make the deal public, citing national security, lawyers Owiso Owiso and Evans Ogada have threatened to move to court.

However, the ministry maintains it followed due process and initiated consultations and reviews before the matter was approved on April 20, when Prime Cabinet Secretary Musalia Mudavadi signed Legal Notice No 82, granting the organisation diplomatic privileges and immunities.

The final approval came on September 20, after a parliamentary team ratified the decision following stakeholder hearings and public participation as mandated by Section 17 of the Act.


Foreign Affairs PS Korir Sing'Oei /EZEKIEL AMING'A

NEWS GENERAL

RISK OF REFOULEMENT

Amnesty raises alarm over arrest of Turkish family

ELIUD KIBII

AMNESTY International has issued an urgent appeal to Kenyan authorities over the arrest of Turkish national Mustafa Güngör and members of his family.

It said Güngör faces a serious risk of refoulement to Türkiye, where he could be subjected to arbitrary detention, torture or other forms of ill treatment.

Amnesty said Güngör was arrested alongside his wife Zeliha, their daughters Seniha Betül and Zeynep and his in-laws Zümrüt and Salim.

The lobby group said it had "reliably learnt" that Turkish authorities sought his arrest through a Mutual Legal Assistance request sent to the Office of the Attorney General of Kenya.

"Kenya has an obligation under international law not to return anyone to a country where they face persecution or harm," Amnesty said.

It urged the Directorate of Criminal Investigations and other authorities to respect the principle of non-refoulement, ensure due process and allow the family continued access to lawyers, the UN Refugee Agency and the Judiciary.

Amnesty officers said they were present at the DCI offices in Upper Hill together with the family's lawyers to monitor the situation.

The case has reignited scrutiny of Kenya's handling of Turkish nationals sought by Ankara, particularly in the context of allegations that some have been forcibly returned despite court orders or pending asylum claims.

Over the past decade, rights groups have documented several cases in which Turkish teachers, businessmen and professionals were arrested in Kenya and subsequently deported to Türkiye.

The arrests are often in connection with accusations by the Turkish government of links to the Gülen movement, which Ankara labels a terrorist organisation.

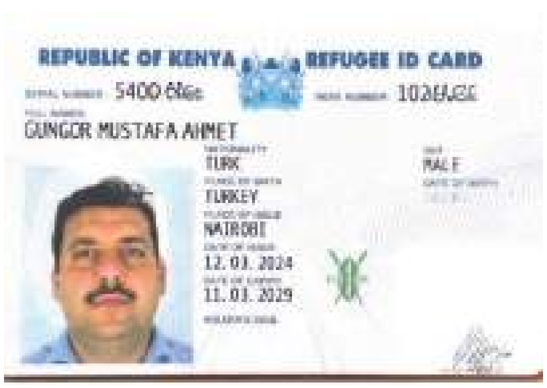
On October 18 last year seven Turkish asylum seekers were abducted in Nairobi and four of them were later sent to Turkey. Mustafa Genç, his son Abdullah Genç, Hüseyin Yesilsu, Necdet Seyitoslu, Öztürk Uzun, Alparslan Tasçı, and his wife Saadet Tasçı were reportedly kidnapped by unknown individuals.

While Abdullah Genç, Seyitoslu and Tasçı were released, Uzun, Tasçı and Yesilsu were refouled, a serious violation of international law.

One of the most cited cases occurred in 2018, when Turkish educator Selahaddin Gülen and businessman Mesut Kacmaz were abducted and later surfaced in Türkiye.

Kenyan authorities denied involvement, but the High Court later ruled that the deportations were illegal and violated the men's constitutional rights.

Similar findings have been made in subsequent cases, with courts affirming that Kenya is bound by its constitution and international treaties to protect individuals from refoulement. Under Article 2(6) of the constitution, international law forms part of Kenyan law, including the 1951 Refugee Convention and the Convention Against Torture both of which prohibit the return of individuals to countries where they face a real risk of torture or persecution. Kenyan courts have repeatedly held that this protection applies regardless of the individual's immigration status.



Mustafa Güngör's refugee ID /HANDOUT

National Assembly's Agriculture and Livestock Committee chairman John Mutunga /FILE

UNCHECKED OVERLAPS

House demands lifestyle audit of tea sector bosses

Report claims conflict of interest is at the heart of depressed tea prices

ELIUD KIBII
@EliudKibii

MPS now want Tea Board of Kenya to conduct urgent lifestyle audit targeting directors, clerks and influential figures in the state-owned tea factories.

The recommendations are contained in a report tabled in Parliament that claims the unchecked overlaps and conflict of interest are at the heart of depressed tea prices hurting farmers. The National Assembly's Agriculture and Livestock Committee has been undertaking an inquiry into the pricing of tea following an outcry over the recent low payout to farmers.

The committee chaired by Tigania West MP John Mutunga said investigations into tea pricing revealed glaring disparities between the earnings of farmers and the lavish lifestyles of some officials charged with managing the sector.

Lawmakers argued that the mismatch points to deep-seated corruption, insider dealings and manipulation of the value chain.

"Tea Board of Kenya should conduct lifestyle audits of the directors, clerks and other influential persons in the factories," the report says.

There are 19 KTDA shareholding tea-processing factories in the West of Rift and 35 in the East of Rift Valley that own KTDA Holdings Limited.

The Tea Board of Kenya is thus the regulator mandated to coordinate, promote and develop Kenya's tea industry ensuring standards, licensing, market development and fair participation for all value-chain actors.

The report exposed widespread mismanagement and governance failures in the tea sector, painting a grim picture of an industry weighed down by weak oversight.

From the report, farmers are short-changed through manipulated scales that under-record delivered green leaf, directly cutting into their earnings.

In several factories, the report highlights that long-serving board members wield excessive influence over key decisions.

The MPs, had observed in the report, in some factories, board members were the main beneficiaries of procurement processes.

In some cases, managers had worked in the same factory for more than 14 years hence familiarity, which affected their performance.

"Cases of falsification of the weighing scale at buying centres were reported in the West of Rift Valley. Some farmers are given less Kgs than what they have supplied therefore reducing their regimes," the report said.

"There is no official forum for consultations for players in the tea sector, particularly the factories (both independent and KTDA factories) to meet and have deliberations on the quality of tea produced by all factories in the country."

They said despite Kenya's tea commanding strong demand globally, growers continue to receive low payouts, a situation they described as deliberate and engineered.

For instance, the report pointed out some mismanagement in factories.

FARMERS ARE SHORT-CHANGED THROUGH MANIPULATED SCALES THAT UNDER-RECORD DELIVERED GREEN LEAF

Also pointed as a contributor to the low tea prices is a situation where 50 per cent of Kenyan teas are sold to two countries, Pakistan and Egypt.

"The government needs to put deliberate efforts to market Kenyan tea in all parts of the world to open up new markets for Kenyan tea," MPs recommended.

"The Ministry of Agriculture and Livestock Development needs to encourage tea factories to explore direct sales of their teas as opposed to relying on the Mombasa tea auction as the main way of selling their teas."

The lawmakers also want the ministry to come up with alternative methods for quality assessment of tea to complement on the commonly used organoleptic method.

Between January and September this year, 431 million kilogrammes of tea were exported, with Pakistan emerging the biggest buyer.

(+) INSTANT ANALYSIS

MPs said despite Kenya's tea commanding strong demand globally, growers continue to receive low payouts, a situation they described as deliberate and engineered.

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BIG READ /NATIONAL AMBITIONS

Kirinyaga Governor Anne Waiguru during the interview /HANDOUT

WAIGURU: MY PUBLIC SERVICE JOURNEY ISN'T ENDING IN 2027

Governor has won acclaim for her leadership in Kirinyaga after overcoming political tribulations

ALICE WAITHERA
@Alicewangechi

As she approaches the final stretch of her second term, Kirinyaga Governor Anne Waiguru has signalled that her public service journey is far from over.

Amid growing speculation about her national ambitions ahead of 2027, the governor speaks candidly about leadership, experience and the future.

From her early days as a government reform adviser and IFMIS director to her role as Cabinet Secretary, where she helped roll out the Huduma programme, Waiguru says her career has prepared her for higher responsibility.

In this wide-ranging interview with the Star, she reflects on legacy, Mt Kenya's political future and why she believes she still has "fuel in the tank".

Q: This being your last term as governor, how do you rate your performance during your tenure?

By God's grace, I have done fairly well. Various assessments and ratings, both from within and outside government, have consistently rated my performance among the top. These evaluations reflect the progress we have made in service delivery, governance and development across the county.

Q: How do you define your leadership style, and how has it evolved over the years?

I define my leadership style as transformative, democratic and widely consultative, especially in the political field. I believe people need to own our programmes for them to succeed, and, therefore, there is a need for delegation, consultation and inclusive leadership.

Q: What single achievement do you believe will define your legacy?

My main legacy will be health. We have improved infrastructure and service delivery across the county.

We upgraded Kerugoya County and Referral Hospital from Level 4 to Level 5, enabling the provision of specialised services. We also upgraded Kimbimbi, Kianyaga and Sagana hospitals from Level 3 to Level 4, expanding the scope of services offered.

> *'I have faced intense political opposition, public scrutiny and moments when my integrity and resolve were questioned. I overcame these challenges by focusing on service delivery and results rather than distractions*

In addition, we have constructed and equipped 24 health facilities to strengthen primary healthcare at the grassroots. We have improved health human resource capacity and digitised all hospitals in the county through the Health Management Information System at Kerugoya Level 5 Hospital and the Electronic Health Information System in all other health facilities.

Q: Beyond health, which other sectors have recorded notable progress under your administration?

In agriculture, we have supported more than 100,000 households through the Wezesha Kirinyaga Programme to improve production and productivity. As a result, farmers' earnings from crops such as rice, coffee, tea and tomatoes have tripled, uplifting many households from poverty.

In trade and industrialisation, we have developed the Sagana Industrial City, which includes an Export Processing Zone, a Special Economic Zone and a County Aggregation and Industrial Park. This is a first and has become a benchmark for other counties. Once complete, the industrial park will enable farmers to earn more through value addition, processing and marketing, and will create more than 10,000 direct jobs and more than 100,000 indirect jobs.

We have also constructed more than 20 new markets, providing farmers and traders with conducive trading environments.

Q: What key infrastructure and service delivery projects stand out during your tenure?

In infrastructure, we have upgraded roads and towns through a cabro paving project, laying more than 118,000 square metres of cabro in Kerugoya, Wang'uru, Sagana, Kagio, Kutus, Kianyaga and Kagumo.

In the water sector, we have supplied more than 100,000 households with adequate water for domestic and irrigation use. We have also digitised revenue collection through the Kiripay System, which has enhanced efficiency, sealed revenue leakages and made it easier for citizens to pay for permits and licences.

Q: Was there any major goal you feel may not be fully achieved by the end of your term?

Our 2018 Mountain Cities 2032 Blueprint designated each constituency as a pillar of our development agenda. Ndia, designated as the county's Industrial City, has progressed

Governor Waiguru with Sagana traders on September 12 /ALICE WAITHERA

Governor Anne Waiguru during the groundbreaking of Kiumbu and Wamumu markets in Kirinyaga on September 11 /ALICE WAITHERA

well with the development of the Sagana Industrial City. Kirinyaga Central, designated as the Wellness City, has taken shape with the upgrading of Kerugoya County and Referral Hospital and the establishment of the Kenya Medical Training College. Mwea has taken off as the county's Agricultural City, particularly as a leading rice and tomato producer.

What we may not have fully achieved by now, but are still on course to deliver, is the development of Gichugu as the county's Resort City. However, we have begun developing a tourism plan to market Gichugu through agritourism, Thiba Dam, Castle Lodge and Mount Kenya climbing trails, which we hope to achieve before my term ends.

Q: How is your administration addressing youth unemployment and economic empowerment in Kirinyaga?

We have streamlined the women and youth agenda across all development programmes and projects. Women and youth form the bulk of beneficiaries under the Wezesha Kirinyaga Programme. We are also positioning young people as the main beneficiaries of employment opportunities at the upcoming Sagana Industrial Park.

In addition, we have a women and youth policy to guide empowerment efforts, as well as a County Empowerment Fund that provides grants to groups undertaking socioeconomic empowerment projects.

The Sagana Industrial Park, as a flagship investment, will create more than 10,000 direct jobs and about 170,000 indirect jobs, significantly boosting household incomes and reducing unemployment in the county.

Q: How do you ensure women and youth are included in leadership and decision-making?

We focus on continuous mentorship and wide consultation on development matters, while providing platforms for women and youth to freely express their views. This includes initiatives such as the Daughters of Kenya (DoK) programme, which encourages participation and leadership development.

The governor arrives for the interview /HANDOUT

'THESE RESPONSIBILITIES HAVE ENHANCED MY CAPACITY FOR PUBLIC LEADERSHIP, AND I BELIEVE THERE IS STILL FUEL IN THE TANK TO SERVE KENYA IN OTHER CAPACITIES'

Q: Mt Kenya is expected to play a decisive role in the 2027 elections. How do you plan to ensure the region's interests are represented in the next government?

We will continue to ensure that the region is represented at the decision-making table. Our priority is to safeguard key projects and protect agriculture, particularly gains made in coffee, tea, rice and milk production.

We are also focused on delivering effective services, such as healthcare, building trust in government through social protection and safeguarding democracy and human rights.

Q: There has been growing speculation that you could be a running mate in 2027. Do you harbour such ambitions?

I have been fortunate to serve Kenya in key responsibilities, including as a government adviser on reforms in my 30s, director of Ifmis and Cabinet Secretary in one of the most impactful ministries, where I initiated the Huduma Programme. I was elected governor in my 40s and re-elected in the 2022 General Election. I also served as chair of the Council of Governors for two years.

These responsibilities have enhanced my capacity for public leadership, and I believe there is still fuel in the tank to serve Kenya in other capacities. I am a committed participant in national development and intend to remain active in politics and governance, serving in any suitable position beyond 2027.

Q: Who has been your role model in politics, and why?

My role model is [former Liberian President] Ellen Johnson Sirleaf, who overcame many obstacles to become Africa's first elected female head of state. She continues to inspire many leaders, particularly women, and remains active in influencing policy even in her 80s.

Q: What challenges have shaped your political career, and how have you overcome them?

My political journey has been shaped by significant challenges that tested my resilience, character and commitment to public service. I have faced intense political opposition, public scrutiny and moments when my integrity and resolve were questioned.

I overcame these challenges by focusing on service delivery and results rather than distractions. I let my work speak for me and relied on faith, family and the support of the people of Kirinyaga.

Q: What is your parting message to Kenyans as the year ends?

We are honoured to be Kenyans, citizens of a country rich in diversity and culture and blessed with immense economic potential. Our nation has matured democratically and is built on a strong constitutional and institutional foundation. It is our duty to preserve, protect and enhance these achievements, and I hope to continue playing a role in this journey.

I also wish all Kenyans a Merry Christmas and a happy and prosperous New Year 2026.

★comment

THE STAR
Lion Place, Waiyaki Way
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Nairobi, Kenya

Make KJSEA placement, revisions clear to parents

THE release of Grade 10 placements has exposed a familiar problem. Parents are anxious, confused and in some cases angry. Much of this tension could have been avoided if the Ministry of Education had explained the placement process more clearly and earlier.

This is the first time Kenya is placing learners into senior secondary school under the new system. The Grade 9 assessment score is not a single exam mark. It is built from the Kenya Primary School Education Assessment, the school-based assessments done in Grades 7 and 8, and only 60 per cent comes from the summative assessment at Grade 9.

This is unfamiliar because most parents still expect a single high-stakes exam to decide everything.

The ministry has said placement was automated and considered learner choice, performance, aptitude, equity and school capacity. That explanation is technically correct, but it is not enough. Parents need simple language. They need to understand why a child with good marks may not land in a school they expected.

The decision not to place all top performers in a few elite schools is commendable. Spreading strong learners across many schools supports equity and can raise standards countrywide.

Still, dissatisfaction is real and it must be handled fairly. When the Kenya Junior School Education Assessment placement revision portal reopens on December 23, parents must be given a genuine chance to seek changes. The process must be transparent, accessible and well explained.

Quote of the day: ***"Great things are not done by impulse, but by a series of small things brought together."*** *—British novelist George Eliot died on December 22, 1880*

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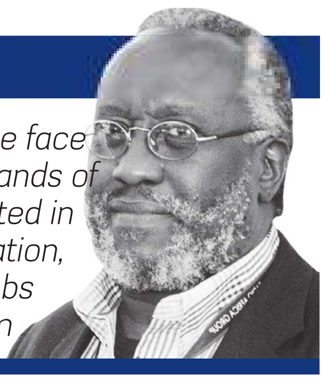
The Star is published by the Star Publications

MYTHS ABOUT KENYAN YOUTH CANNOT BE TAKEN SERIOUSLY

By Wycliffe Muga



They console us in the face of hundreds of thousands of families having invested in their children's education, only to find that no jobs are available for them

EVERY country, to some degree, has its myths which help define who its citizens believe themselves to be, and where they, as a people, believe they are going.

Kenyan mythology has for some time been dominated by the claim that the large numbers of young Kenyans currently arriving at adulthood, our so-called 'youth bulge', is a good thing.

And the frequent conclusion of those who talk or write about this, is that we stand to receive a 'demographic dividend' from this youth bulge.

Along with this favourable assessment is the equally frequent claim that Kenyan youths are 'tech-savvy'. And that this creates for an environment in which innovations are bound to thrive, especially as Nairobi is a recognised 'innovation hub'.

All this would be very good news indeed if it were true.

But is it really?

First, I would point out that in any country at all, those who have the capacity to innovate – the skills needed as much as the drive to work relentlessly towards their goals – are invariably a tiny minority. A minority so small that it has a negligible impact on employment statistics.

So, if we are trying to look into job creation, we need to consider instead the services and products that these entrepreneurial innovators have been able to come up with, which might evolve into new businesses.

And on this, the record of success is rather thin. If we take an arbitrary base of measurement and say that for any such ICT-based innovation to be taken seriously, it has to be used regularly by at least one million Kenyans, we find that most of the innovations that qualify were invented either in China or in the US.

Our only outstanding success in this field is Safaricom's M-Pesa. It remains our gold standard as an innovation that created many thousands of jobs and improved the lives and livelihoods of millions.

But M-Pesa's cash transfer service has now been in existence for over 20 years. And so far, no new success of similar potential has appeared on our horizons.

The other issue raised by this mythology is that having large numbers of young people within a country is an inherently good thing.

I would argue that this depends entirely on the country's ability to create economic opportunity for these young people.

Everything I read about the new age of artificial intelligence suggests that the advances expected in AI, automation and digitisation will lead to fewer jobs, not more. There will always be things which AI cannot do. But where it works, it raises productivity by making it possible for every worker to do more with the aid of machines.

Given that ours is still a predominantly agrarian economy, consider this: there are already remote-controlled mini tractors available, which can effortlessly do the work of roughly a dozen strong men.

If a day comes when the prices of such tractors have dropped low enough to make them as affordable as the ubiquitous boda boda motorcycles, this will dramatically enhance farm productivity. But it would lead to far fewer farm jobs, not more.

So, all this talk of our beneficial 'youth bulge' and its correspondent claim to Kenya having an advanced ICT ecosystem which will empower young entrepreneurs to 'innovate' our way to national prosperity, cannot be taken seriously.

It is but part of our national mythology; it consoles us in the face of hundreds of thousands of families having invested in their children's education, only to find that no jobs are available for these well-qualified youths.

Our problem is not at the entrepreneurial level. It is at the policy level: consecutive leaderships have simply not found a way to grow the economy at a pace that enables it to absorb all these young people into suitable employment.

This is not a uniquely Kenyan problem. I don't know much about the economy of the UK, but I keep reading how both the Labour Party and the Conservative Party (the two leading political parties in the country) have not been able to come up with policies that will pull the country out of its current state of unacceptably low economic growth.

Wycliffe Muga is a columnist

Is he right? Tell us what YOU think.
email opinion@radioafricagroup.co.ke

VOICES

WHY ENTREPRENEURSHIP HOLDS THE KEY TO LASTING PROSPERITY

By Kenneth Njeru

As modern tools spread, we are likely to see many young Kenyans building companies, creating solutions, and competing globally in ways that would have seemed unrealistic just a decade ago

Lasting prosperity in any nation does not come from government spending alone, nor is it sustained by natural resources or foreign aid. It comes from entrepreneurs; people who see problems around them, decide to fix them, start businesses, employ others and slowly build wealth. Aid and resources can help in the short term, but over time, every successful economy is powered by people who are willing to innovate and execute.

That is why the government's most important role is not to run the economy, but to enable it. This means getting the basics right: good roads, reliable electricity, affordable internet, functional healthcare and a strong education system. Crucially, it also means fostering a regulatory environment that allows a small business to scale quickly without facing bureaucratic extortion or complex county licensing hurdles.

Singapore is often cited for good reason. When it became independent in 1965, it had very little in terms of natural resources. What it did have was a long-term vision. By investing heavily in education and infrastructure, it built one of the most skilled workforces in the world and positioned itself as a global business and technology hub.

Kenya could not realistically have taken that path in the 1960s or 1970s. Literacy levels were low, and access to education was limited. The human capital required to drive a modern economy simply did not yet exist.

That reality is now changing fast, largely because of technology. Access to knowledge is no longer limited to elite institutions or major cities. While Julius Yego is not known for business success, his story remains one of the clearest and most widely understood examples of what happens when talent in a developing country is given access to information.

Growing up in a rural area without access to elite coaching, Yego taught himself javelin technique by watching videos of the world's best athletes online. That self-driven learning led him to become world champion in 2015 and an Olympic silver medallist in 2016, demonstrating just how transformative access to knowledge can be.

AI is likely to multiply this effect. AI is lowering barriers across industries by making complex tasks easier, providing access to expertise on demand and shortening learning curves that once took years. This also makes meritocracy easier to quantify, as real-time performance data, whether code output or sales metrics, becomes the true measure of contribution.

As these tools spread, we are likely to see many young Kenyans building companies, creating solutions, and competing globally in ways that would have seemed unrealistic just a decade ago.

At the same time, success in this new environment must be grounded in humility. Those who thrive today are doing so with tools that previous generations never had. There was no YouTube, no cloud computing and certainly no AI. Many people built businesses and careers under far tougher conditions, without shortcuts or instant access to information. Modern success stories often rest on foundations that simply did not exist before, and that reality should temper how we view ourselves and our opinions.

Kenya has also made meaningful institutional progress. Today, registering a company online through eCitizen takes just a few days. Not long ago, that same process involved paperwork, queues and uncertainty. We are human, however, and we tend to focus more on what is still broken than on the steady progress that has quietly taken place. It should be this way to avoid getting complacent.

Difficult choices still lie ahead. Populist ideas can be attractive, especially in hard economic times, but they rarely deliver lasting results. Real progress often takes years, even decades, to show. Kenya is currently benefiting from long-term decisions such as the introduction of free primary education in 2003, which significantly increased school enrolment and helped produce a larger, more educated generation now entering the workforce.

To make the most of this moment, meritocracy needs to become second nature. Opinions should carry weight based on what someone has actually done, not how loud they are or how many followers they have. No one is an expert in everything, and pretending otherwise does more harm than good. Sharing strong opinions on subjects one has never spent thousands of hours working on, often triggered by a short social media clip with its own agenda, adds noise rather than insight.

Social media has made this problem worse. Today, visibility is often confused with competence. Someone with a large following but no record of building a sustainable business is treated as an authority. This misalignment is especially dangerous for young people genuinely trying to learn.

Ironically, some of the most valuable voices in entrepreneurship are the least appreciated by the people who need to listen. A good example is a Kenyan entrepreneur with over two decades of real business experience who recently started a podcast. The discussions are practical, honest and grounded in lived experience, featuring founders who have actually built companies. Yet the podcast is gaining traction slowly, largely because it avoids fashionable buzzwords and hype. It is a reminder that substance does not always travel as fast as spectacle, but it is substance that ultimately matters.

Kenya's education system has had its challenges, but it has also quietly shaped many high performers. Subjects like Business Studies and Agriculture in high school introduced practical thinking, enterprise and problem-solving to students. Many Kenyans who excel today in business and agribusiness were first exposed to these ideas in the classroom. It will be interesting to see what the Competency-Based Education system produces, especially as it places greater emphasis on skills, creativity, and individual strengths.

The next challenge is accelerating knowledge transfer. Kenya needs more experienced entrepreneurs openly sharing what they have learned, not just through isolated initiatives, but through structured public-private mentorship programmes and accessible digital platforms led by proven industry veterans. Honest conversations and dedicated mentorship can dramatically shorten the learning curve for the next generation, ensuring that hard-won wisdom is not lost.

There is a need for the ethos of quantifying merit in all our lives. We must begin to apply a rigorous lens to all advice and influence: Does this person, in this matter, have merit? Have they achieved what I idealise in that field? This mindset, one that values proven competence over celebrity, network or sentiment, is humbling and empowering.

Director Africa Afya Healthcare

Align skills policies with industry-led training

By Andrew Kimeu

Policy will not resolve the issue of construction skills in Kenya, but deliberate collaborations will ensure that policy is transformed into practice

THE local and global labour markets are experiencing rapid changes. These changes have been brought about by developments such as digitisation, globalisation, demographic changes and climate change, including the green transition.

New occupations are emerging while others are changing or becoming obsolete. In response to this, the government, in its efforts to fulfil the constitutional provisions on relevant education and employment, worked in collaboration with stakeholders to develop the National Skills Development Policy 2023.

The overall goal of this policy is to promote sustainable socioeconomic development by developing a skilled workforce that is employable, productive, enterprising, innovative, adaptable and competitive.

The policy has been developed in response to the skills mismatch, which has contributed to high youth unemployment in the country. The policy, therefore, provides a coordinated response to the skills mismatch towards developing an education and training system that is responsive to labour market demands.

The policy framework covers the broad areas of governance and management, human capital development, education and employability, entrepreneurship education, labour market information and skills anticipation, school-to-work transition, skills for national development priorities, skills for the economy and skills for non-traditional and new occupations.

Separately, in November 2025, Kenya launched the National Dual Training Policy, marking a key milestone in transforming technical and vocational education and enhancing youth employability. The new policy establishes a structured framework for integrating classroom instruction with hands-on industry experience, ensuring graduates acquire both theoretical knowledge and practical skills aligned with market demands.

The Dual Training Policy guides institutions, employers and trainers in delivering structured work-based learning, strengthening quality standards, and promoting sustainable skills development aligned with industry needs.

In tandem with these two policies, the China Road and Bridge Corporation has established targeted skills-training and development programmes for employees. These initiatives are designed to upgrade technical capabilities and foster long-term career advancement, serving as a key pillar of CRBC's social-responsibility commitment and its strategy for harmonious coexistence with host communities.

The company has trained tens of thousands of talents in infrastructure technology and operational management during its overseas projects, including in Kenya. Kenyan trainees have studied railway and road operations and management through CRBC-supported scholarship programmes. This is a strong indicator of skills transfer, which directly strengthens Kenya's construction and engineering workforce.

The skills transfer couldn't have come at a better time. The skills gap in Kenya's construction industry is wide, well-documented and a clear barrier to national development goals. Evidence from the World Bank, Ministry of Labour and Federation of Kenya Employers shows that Kenya urgently needs stronger technical training, better industry-Technical and Vocational Education and Training collaboration, more hands-on, competency-based learning and greater investment in mid-level skills. Without closing this gap, Kenya's infrastructure ambitions will continue to rely on external expertise, slowing long-term economic transformation.

The company has actively considered and implemented specialised programmes and initiatives dedicated to construction and workforce skills development, particularly with a focus on nurturing young, entry-level professionals. These efforts are part of CRBC's broader corporate social responsibility strategy and its commitment to technology transfer and local capacity building in the countries where it operates.

But compared to China, Kenya's construction sector faces deep structural barriers that limit the adoption of modern training methods—far beyond Internet connectivity or electricity issues. Kenya struggles with weaker industry–training integration, outdated equipment, low digital adoption, fragmented industry practices, insufficient funding and safety challenges. These systemic issues slow down the modernisation of construction training and limit Kenya's ability to fully leverage advanced methods used in China.

In the end, policy will not resolve the issue of construction skills in Kenya, but deliberate collaborations will ensure that policy is transformed into practice.

Diplomacy and communication practitioner

★letters

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Leaders can be re-elected on the basis of work done rather than drama staged

FOR far too long, Kenyan politics has been weighed down by empty rhetoric, endless name-calling and lofty promises that rarely translate into tangible change. Election seasons are often marked by beautifully crafted manifestos, powerful slogans and emotional appeals meant to excite the electorate.

Yet once the ballots are counted and leaders are sworn into office, many of these promises are quietly shelved, neatly packed away in drawers, while the people wait in vain for delivery.

This pattern has cost us dearly. It has bred cynicism among citizens, weakened trust in leadership and slowed the pace of development. Kenyans deserve better. Leadership should not be about who speaks the loudest, insults the most or masters political theatrics. It should be about who delivers.

Perfection in leadership does not exist. What should exist, however, is commitment. Commitment to serve, to deliver and to honour the mandate given by the people. When citizens entrust a leader with a five-year term, they are not doing so for entertainment or endless political drama. They are offering an opportunity to make a real difference in their lives.

The time has come for us, as a nation, to rethink how we judge leadership. Development, not rhetoric, should be the true measure of political success.

History offers us a powerful lesson. The late former President Mwai Kibaki exemplified this kind of leadership. He was not known for fiery speeches or political grandstanding. He was a man of few words, minimal politics and firm focus. Yet more than a decade after he left office, Kenyans still speak about his development record. His legacy endures not because of what he said, but because of what he did.

That is the kind of leadership Kenya needs today. Leaders who genuinely mean well for their people must be ready to emulate this model. Less noise and more work. Development has a way of speaking for itself. A new road, a functioning hospital, a reliable water supply, empowered youth or improved access to education does not need a press conference to be felt. The people experience it in their daily lives.

Some of us have consciously chosen this path by remaining focused on our mandate to deliver while keeping politics in the background. I have consistently stated that I am not prepared to engage in political contests, premature campaigns or name-calling at the expense of development. I have a manifesto to implement.

> “When citizens entrust a leader with a five-year term, they are not doing so for entertainment or endless political drama...Political distractions do not build classrooms. Insults do not employ young people. Endless rallies do not put food on the table for our people.

Predictably, attempts have been made to distract me from this mission. Some political actors have tried unsuccessfully to drag me into the mud of political wrestling. Others have deployed all manner of tricks and provocations, hoping to derail focus and shift attention from service delivery to political drama. I have declined these invitations not out of fear, but out of conviction.

Political distractions do not build classrooms. Insults do not employ young people. Endless rallies do not put food on the table for our people.

In just three years, in Kiambu we have built 512 new ECDE centres, started a comprehensive feeding programme that provides free uji, milk and eggs, constructed six new level 4 and 26 level 3 hospitals, installed 12,000 solar streetlights, and given farm inputs (maize seeds, beans, fertiliser, piglets and chicks) to over 700,000 farmers.

We also managed to increase own source revenue from Sh2.9 billion to Sh5.45 billion after we installed a new Enterprise Planning Resource System that automates all county services.

Today's voter is more informed, more discerning and more demanding. Citizens are increasingly able to separate the wheat from the chaff. They can tell the difference between noise and substance, between promises and performance. This awakening should serve as a wake-up call to leaders who still believe that political gymnastics alone can sustain a career.

It is entirely possible, and indeed desirable, for a leader to be elected and re-elected on the basis of work done rather than drama staged. That is why I have deliberately chosen not to engage in premature politics. There will be a time for campaigns. For me, that time is 2027, when the country goes to the polls. Until then, my responsibility is clear. To deliver!

When that time comes, I will return to the people with a report card. I will ask them to assess my performance, what I achieved, what I did not and how faithfully I implemented the manifesto we agreed upon. I will invite them to mark the examination. That, in my view, is how democracy should work.

Kimani Wamatangi
Governor of Kiambu county

PICTURE OF THE DAY

World Health Organization Director General Dr Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus and Health Cabinet Secretary Aden Duale during a strategic bilateral engagement on the sidelines of the ongoing second WHO Global Summit on Traditional Medicine in India /HANDOUT

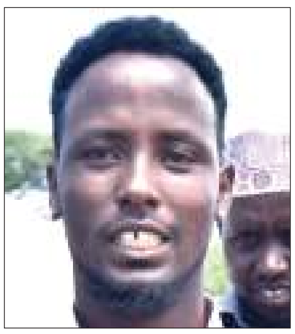
COMPILED BY STEPHEN ASTARIKO

Will you be travelling during the festive season?

★new voices

No. I will not be travelling, as has always been the case. Life has become difficult, and the cost of living has gone up. Not forgetting that January is around the corner and school fees will be required. I have decided to stay quietly to avoid extra expenses. I hope and pray that things become better next year.

HANNA KIMWELE
Resident, Garissa



No. I will stay around and go back to college in January to continue with my studies. Christmas is mostly celebrated by our Christian brothers and sisters, who are the ones who travel to their rural places to meet up with their loved ones. For us Muslims, December is a month like any other. I, however, wish our Christian brethren the best as they celebrate this holiday.

ABDI SHURIE
Resident, Garissa

★STAR COMMENT **Yes. It is my norm to travel and join my family members for the holiday. This will be no different. But to be honest, times are tough and given the option, I would have preferred to stay behind and celebrate quietly. The economy is not making things any better. I don't understand what is happening; it seems like life is getting tougher with each passing day. We have children to feed and educate, and yet things continue getting tougher. Our children are expecting Christmas gifts, but we cannot provide them. May God us see us through.**

JUSTA KATHAMBI
Resident, Garissa

No. Life is not easy at the moment. Travelling for the holidays would only add pressure, so my family will celebrate right here at home. I survive on daily wages, and December is usually unpredictable. If I travel, I might come back broke. Staying put helps me manage my expenses better. With school fees and other bills coming up in January, travelling now would strain my finances.

KITAVI MUSYOKA
Resident, Garissa

Yes. This holiday is the only time when families come together to celebrate and thank God. As a family, we have made it a habit to celebrate it in style. But one thing I must admit, and which I am sure many Kenyans will agree, is that life has become extremely expensive due to the tough economic times. This has greatly affected Christmas celebrations.

ELIAS MUKARIA
Resident, Garissa

society...

Who's in and who's out
In the local hotspots

KENYANS IN ETHIOPIA GIFT NEW MOTHERS IN PUMWANI

ON Saturday, Kenya's outgoing ambassador to Ethiopia Amb George Orina and Kenya Wanachi Association in Ethiopia chairperson **Julia Salim** led the Kenyan diaspora in Ethiopia in a charity event at the Pumwani Maternity Hospital, Nairobi, where they presented gift packages to mothers of newborn babies at the facility.

The charity drive is consistent with President **William Ruto's** objective of mainstreaming the Kenyan diaspora for the country's socioeconomic development.

The hospital event was the culmination of year-long activities by the KWAE, which has seen Kenyans in Ethiopia contribute towards the welfare on their fellow countrymen and women, as well as those of their Ethiopian brothers and sisters.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1. Amb George Orina (4th left), Pascalin Kimongu of Pumwani Maternity and Julia Salim with members of the Kenyan diaspora **2.** A mother is handed gifts by Amb Orina **3.** Mothers receive gift packages **4.** Amb Orina with gift packages for mothers of newborn babies at the facility **5.** Amb Orina gifts a staff members **/HANDOUT**


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POMP AND COLOUR AS **RADIO AFRICA AWARDS ITS FINEST**

RADIO Africa Group held the end-year party on Thursday. Various staff were awarded on their achievements throughout the year.

In attendance were the chief executive officer **Martin Khafafa**, editorial director **Paul Ilado**, head of finance **James Mundia** and HR manager **Jemima Ngode**.


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1. James Mundia hands over the Star Business Award to team members Martin Mwita, Jacktone Lawi and Victor Amadala **2.** Paul Ilado receives a trophy from Martin Khafafa **3.** Jemima Ngode awards Moses Ogada the Political Reporter of the Year award **4.** Moses Mwangi receives Photographer of the Year award from digital editor Francis Mureithi **5.** Star online team member Loreen Wamalwa, HR executive Caroline Moi, online deputy editor Nancy Agutu, online subeditors Tabnacha Oduor and Damaris Kiilu, and video editor Tracy Muthoni **6.** Caleb Benton dances after winning the Client Whisperer Award **7.** The Star factory team and the company's receptionist Jane Muthoni (R) **8.** Josephine Kamau poses with her trophy and certificate for Radio Africa Group HR Person of the Year award **/ENOS TECHE**

SUPPORTING WOMEN

Senator Mutinda launches bid for Nairobi Woman Rep seat

JULIUS OTIENO

THE race for the Nairobi County Woman Representative seat is shaping up to be highly competitive.

With less than two years to the 2027 General Election, multiple aspirants have already positioning themselves to succeed incumbent Esther Passaris.

The contest intensified after nominated Senator Tabitha Mutinda formally launched her bid for the seat, which she is seeking on President William Ruto's UDA ticket.

Mutinda's entry comes as Passaris has confirmed she will not defend the seat after completing two terms.

"By 2027, God willing, I will have completed two full terms as Nairobi Woman Rep. This is an affirmative action seat and I believe it is time for another woman to lead," Passaris said last month.

Passaris was first elected Nairobi Woman Representative in 2017 and successfully defended the seat in the 2022 General Election.

Senate Finance and Budget Committee chairperson Tabitha Mutinda in Parliament on November 6 /HANDOUT

Mutinda officially launched her campaign on Friday at the University of Nairobi's School of Science along Ngong Road.

Addressing supporters, she highlighted her grassroots engagement with women groups.

"I have been working with fellow women in Nairobi, empowering them through table banking. We have touched lives in all the 17 subcounties, and that is what I want to continue doing," Mutinda said.

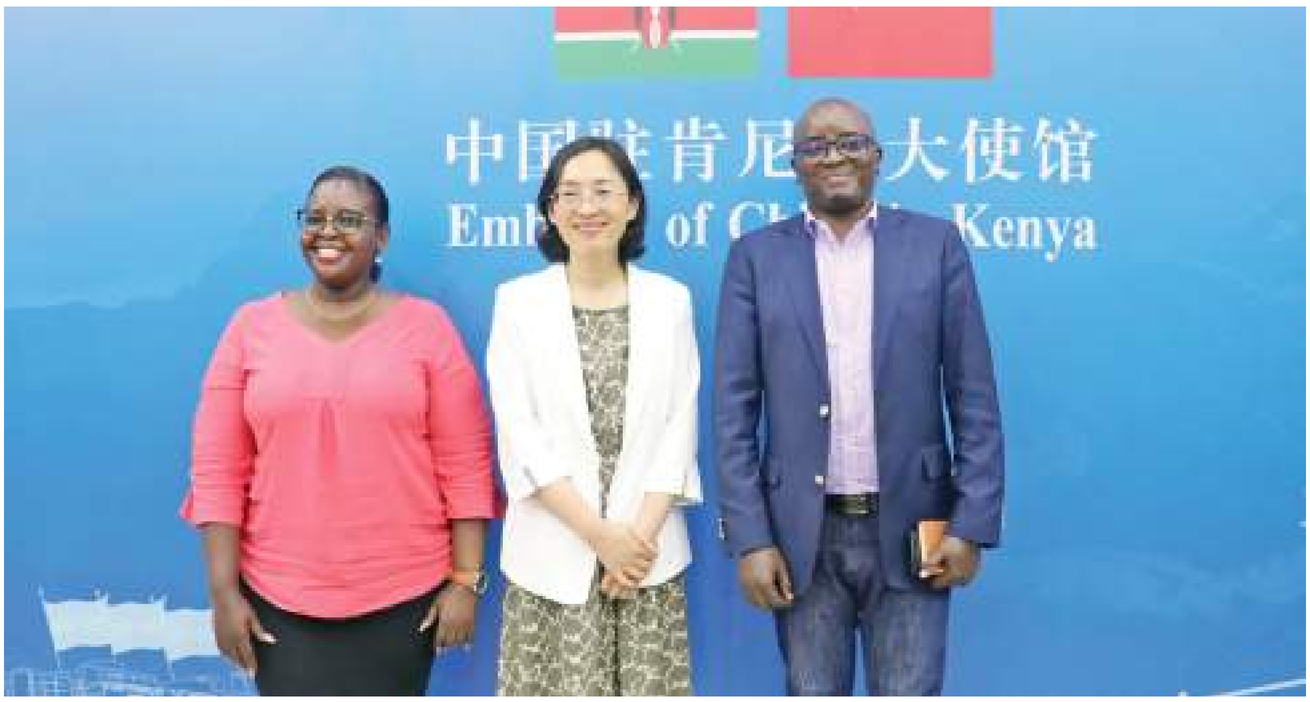


PHOTO STORY

Radio Africa Group head of electronic news Susan Kimachia, Chinese ambassador to Kenya Guo Haiyan and Radio Africa Group digital head Francis Mureithi during the end-year dinner party with Kenyan journalists at the Chinese embassy in Kenya on December 18 /LEAH MUKANGAI

SHORE REVENUE

City Hall rolls out land rates waiver, threatens prosecution

Says just about a quarter of the capital's registered land parcels are compliant

PETER OBUYA
@Pobuya

CITY Hall has rolled out a festive land rates waiver aimed at encouraging landowners to pay up to shore revenues for better services to residents.

The county government had also issued a warning that strict enforcement and prosecutions under the National Rating Act will follow once the window closes.

City Hall says just about a quarter of the capital's registered land parcels are compliant, a gap officials blame for chronic shortfalls in funding roads, waste management, health services and public lighting.

The one-off waiver, running from December 15 to December 31, 2025, removes 100 per cent of accumulated interest and penalties for landowners who clear their arrears within the period, offering what authorities describe as a final soft landing before the law takes full effect.

Receiver of Revenue Tiras Njoroge said the incentive is meant to ease pressure on ratepayers during the festive season while shoring up the county's own-source revenue.

"This is an opportunity to correct any outstanding land rates. Take advantage of the waiver, which wipes out all interest and penalties. From January 1, it will not be business as usual, any unpaid amount will be treated as default," he said.

Earlier, Governor Sakaja Johnson revealed that out of 250,000 registered land parcels in Nairobi, only about 50,000 are paying land rates.

"The biggest revenue earner in a city is property taxes. Having only a quarter of landowners paying is not sustainable," he said, linking poor compliance directly to stalled service delivery.

Sakaja noted that with complete data now available for all parcels, enforcement will intensify after the waiver. "We have given enough time. Going forward, we shall enforce so that we can deliver services to residents," he said, adding that legal measures including clamping of buildings remain an option for persistent defaulters.

Ratepayers can access their bills through nairobiservices.go.ke or visit City Hall Annexe and subcounty offices, with phone and email support available.

Njoroge reiterated that once the waiver lapses, defaulters will be required to pay the full principal alongside reinstated interest and penalties.

City Hall is urging landowners to seize the waiver, insisting that improved compliance is key to sustainable revenue and better services across the capital.

According to official reports, the amount in unpaid land rates tells of the crisis in the city's governance.

The principal amount of land rates owed to Nairobi City Hall stands at Sh55.2 billion.

What's worse, the figure highlighted in the Controller of Budget report for the period to September 2025, is not static.

It grows steadily with each passing quarter, as evidenced by an additional Sh1.29 billion that went unpaid in just the three-month period leading up to that date.

The roots of this massive debt lie in a culture of widespread non-compliance, where only a fraction of property owners fulfill their civic duty.

RATEPAYERS CAN ACCESS THEIR BILLS THROUGH NAIROBI-SERVICES.GO.KE OR VISIT CITY HALL ANNEXE

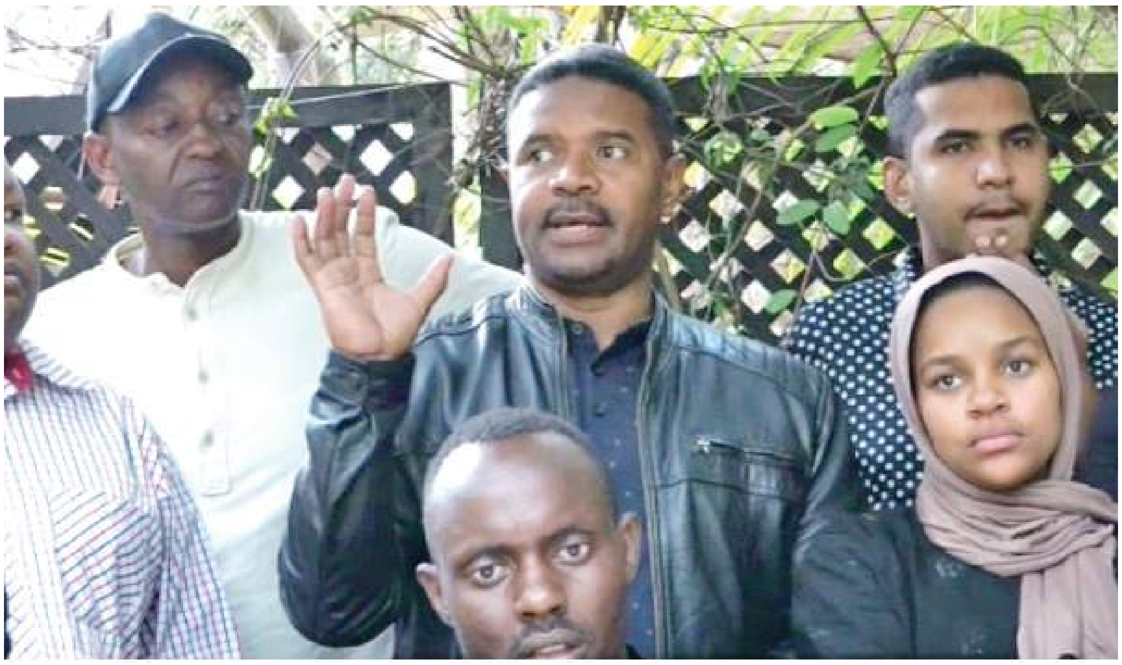
NEWS COUNTIES

ABANDONED

We want to know our fathers, demand kids of Batuk soldiers

Unable to fit in in community, referred to as 'mzungu', but come from poor backgrounds

ALICE WAITHERA
@Alicewangechi



Human rights activists led by Vocal Africa CEO Hussein Khalid during a press conference in Nanyuki town, Laikipia, on December 19 /ALICE WAITHERA

THREE youth thought to have been fathered by British soldiers in Nanyuki, Laikipia county, have called for the fast-tracking of their recognition by the UK government following a court ruling in their favour.

In October, London's Family Court issued a ruling in favour of seven Kenyans, confirming that they were fathered by British nationals living in Kenya.

Six of the fathers worked with the British Army Training Unit Kenya (Batuk) while one was a contractor and the paternity was confirmed using public DNA databases.

Addressing a press conference in Nanyuki, three of those abandoned narrated the struggles they encountered as they were brought up by single mothers.

They explained their inability to fit into the community as their peers referred to them as 'mzungu' due to their mixed race, despite coming from poor backgrounds.

"I had to drop out and help to take care of my siblings. Life has been very difficult because the only jobs available are not that well-paying," one said.

All they ever wanted, he said, was to be accepted as part of the community even though they looked different.

Another said when he asked his mother who his father was, he did not get an answer.

His family, he added, lived in abject poverty and he grew up watching his mother struggle to raise him and his siblings.

"When people refer to me as a white man, it makes me feel segregated. I did not choose to be born this way or even where to be born," he said.

Hussein Khalid, a human rights activist and the CEO of Vocal Africa, observed that the community living near Batuk's training area has been grappling with many challenges over the years.

He pointed out that the soldiers leave weaponry in the fields that explode on locals grazing their cattle, maiming them and killing their livestock. "The explosives release some gases that are thought to contaminate the environment—including the water that they drink—which affects their health and that of their cattle," he said.

Further, whenever there's compensation, the money is channelled to non-victims while victims are left reeling in losses.

In August, the High Court in the UK ordered that children in Kenya allegedly fathered and abandoned by British soldiers be given access to the identities of the men involved.

The ruling required the Department for Work and Pensions and HM Revenue and Customs in Britain to disclose the last known contact details of the 11 men.

The ruling has opened the door for such children, estimated to be in their hundreds, to seek British citizenship and financial support.

A study conducted by Amnesty International reported over 650 rape allegations against British soldiers between 1965 and 2001, primarily in areas like Dol Dol, Archers Post and Wamba.

Michael Monicah, a paralegal, said the Laikipia Paralegal Organisation is working with partners to support those adversely affected.

"The lives of children sired by the soldiers have been turned upside down. They face serious difficulties right from their childhoods and we have the burden of proving their parentage," Monicah said.

(+) INSTANT ANALYSIS

A report released by the National Assembly in November also revealed a disturbing trend of sexual misconduct by Batuk personnel, including rape, assault and abandonment of children fathered by soldiers. The report, released by the Departmental Committee on Defence, Intelligence and Foreign Relations following a two-year inquiry, accused the British Army of persistently declining to appear before the committee and invoking diplomatic immunity.

RISE IN INFECTIONS

Kenya misses WHO award over high HIV rates in babies

JOHN MUCHANGI

Kenya is recording a worrying rise in infections among newborns, threatening years of progress /HANDOUT

THE high rate of babies being born with HIV has again cost Kenya global validation.

The World Health Organization last week only validated Brazil for ending vertical transmission of the virus.

WHO's announcement that Brazil had met the criteria for eliminating mother-to-child HIV transmission highlights a stark contrast with Kenya's current situation.

"Eliminating mother-to-child transmission of HIV is a major public health achievement for any country, especially for a country as large and complex as Brazil," said Dr Tedros Ghebreyesus, WHO director general.

"Brazil has shown that with sustained political commitment and equitable access to quality health services, every country can ensure that every child is born free of HIV and every mother receives the care she deserves."

Brazil succeeded in reducing vertical transmission of HIV to below two per cent and achieved high coverage for prenatal care and timely treatment for pregnant women living with HIV.

"This achievement shows that eliminating vertical transmission of HIV is possible when pregnant women know their HIV status, receive timely treatment and have access to maternal health services and safe delivery," said Dr Jarbas Barbosa, director of WHO in South America.

"It is also the result of the tireless dedication of thousands of health professionals, community health workers and civil society organisations."

While Brazil marked a historic milestone, Kenya recorded a worrying rise in infections among newborns, threatening years of progress.

The National Syndemic Diseases Control Council data indicates that a total of 20,105 new HIV cases were identified in Kenya in 2024.

Children under 15 years accounted for 4,349 of the new infections, highlighting persistent vulnerabilities in mother-to-child transmission despite intensive prevention efforts.

The high MTCT rates occur despite relatively high coverage of prevention of mother-to-child transmission (PMTCT) services, which reached about 90.1 per cent in 2024.

"Kenya's Prevention of Mother-to-Child Transmission coverage stands at 90.1 per cent, yet the mother-to-child transmission (MTCT) rate remains at 9.26 per cent," the NSDCC said.

Still, the persistent transmission reflects gaps in accessing and completing the full continuum of care for mothers and infants.

Kenya's national HIV elimination targets aim for a less than five per cent elimination of mother-to-child transmission (EMTCT) rate by 2030.

To earn EMTCT status, a country must document sustained low transmission rates, typically under two–five per cent, strong antenatal care and treatment coverage, reliable data systems and human rights–oriented service delivery.

Gaps in care are most pronounced in Kenya's arid and semi-arid counties, where cultural barriers, stigma, and low antenatal attendance persist.

In regions such as Wajir, Mandera, Isiolo and Samburu, more than one in five infants born to HIV-positive mothers contract the virus, with some counties reporting rates exceeding 20 per cent.

Botswana is the only African country validated by WHO as having eliminated mother-to-child transmission of HIV as a public health problem, earning Gold Tier status for reducing the transmission rate to around 1.2 per cent and meeting the rigorous service coverage and data criteria.

This makes it the first high HIV-burden nation in the world and the first in Africa to achieve this milestone.

HEALTHCARE

Jomvu needs a level 4 hospital to handle emergencies – Faki

BRIAN OTIENO

A level 4 hospital that can handle emergency cases should be built in Jomvu subcounty, Mombasa Senator Mohamed Faki has said.

The hospital, Faki said, should be similar to or better than the one in Port Reitz in Changamwe subcounty.

Faki said Jomvu subcounty has only four public health facilities all of which are Level 3 and below, despite having a huge population.

"We have enough land to accommodate a Level 4 hospital in Jomvu. We need a health facility that can handle emergencies like the Coast General Teaching and Referral Hospital," the senator said.

He spoke on Sunday during a free medical camp organised by his office in collaboration with the Jomvu Youth Network in Vikobani in Jomvu constituency.

People from Mikindani and Miritini can easily access Jomvu.

The senator said the existing four health facilities in the subcounty should also be expanded because of the services they provide.

"The CDF hospital is located in a big catchment area but the facility is so congested because of the little space it occupies," Faki said.

"This makes it not give services as adequately as it should. In January, I visited the facility and the maternity bed has rust, which is dangerous to the mother and the child."

Faki said health services in Jomvu need improvement because the subcounty is the last one in Mombasa after which one moves to Kilifi and Kwale counties, and is also the first one when one comes in from Kilifi and Kwale counties through the West part of Mombasa.

"We must have a facility here that can handle emergencies such as accidents," he said.

The senator said road accidents along the Mombasa-Nairobi highway occur but victims have to go all the way to the Coast General Teaching and Referral Hospital in Mvita constituency, bypassing Jomvu and Changamwe subcounties.

Having a facility closer to can help save lives, the senator said. "You can remember some time back a plane crashed at Mataa ya Ndege. Two people died, including the pilot. But if the plane was bigger, carrying more people, it would have been a bigger disaster because there is no health facility in Jomvu that can handle such emergencies," Faki said.

Mombasa Senator Mohamed Faki donates blood during a free medical camp in Vikobani, Jomvu constituency in Mombasa county on Sunday /BRIAN OTIENO

INDIGENOUS KNOWLEDGE

State mulls use of herbal medication in hospitals

CS Duale says move will be guided by laws and standards that are still being developed

JOHN MUCHANGI
@Jomunji

Health CS Aden Duale in Chuka town, Tharaka Nithi county /HANDOUT

KENYA has promised to integrate herbal and traditional medicines into the national health system.

However, the move will be guided by laws and standards that are still being developed.

Health Cabinet Secretary Aden Duale said the government wants the process to protect patients, respect culture and support universal health coverage.

Duale spoke in New Delhi, India, during the World Health Organization's Second Global Summit on Traditional Medicine, where ministers, scientists, indigenous leaders and practitioners from more than 100 countries gathered to shape the future of traditional medicine worldwide.

The CS said Kenya recognises the long role of traditional medicine in communities and wants to bring it into the formal health system in an organised and safe way.

"Kenya's Traditional, Complementary and Integrative Medicine (TCIM) approach prioritises patient safety, scientific evidence, innovation, environmental stewardship and the respectful integration of indigenous knowledge," Duale said.

"Kenya's constitution safeguards biodiversity, promotes equitable benefit-sharing and recognises indigenous knowledge as a cornerstone of sustainable development."

He said the government is already putting in place key laws and guidelines to make this happen.

"To operationalise this vision, Kenya has established a comprehensive policy and regulatory framework, including the Traditional, Complementary and Integrative Medicine Policy, the Traditional Health Practitioners Bill, the National Research Framework and the Herbalists' Handbook. These instruments are designed to professionalise practice, strengthen safety and quality standards and enhance evidence generation," Duale said.

Traditional medicine is widely used in Kenya, especially in rural areas and informal settlements in towns. Most of these practices operate outside the formal health system, with little regulation.

The Ministry of Health said regulation of herbal and traditional medicine products is currently handled by the Pharmacy and Poisons Board, which oversees products from development to sale.

The board uses digital regulatory systems and expert committees to assess safety and quality.

Kenya is also recognised as a Regional Centre of Regulatory Excellence in pharmacovigilance, meaning it plays a leading role in monitoring medicine safety in the region.

Duale said technology is helping improve oversight. Digital tools and artificial intelligence are being used to speed up evaluation, improve transparency and strengthen decision making on herbal products.

He said beyond safety, the government sees traditional medicine as an economic opportunity.

"Kenya is also strengthening research and innovation through strategic partnerships that leverage artificial intelligence, genomics and digital platforms to improve standardisation, strengthen evidence and support the global integration of validated TCIM practices," Duale said.

The long-term plan is to bring traditional medicine into primary healthcare in a structured way.

This would include accrediting practitioners, setting clear referral systems between traditional healers and hospitals, expanding research and possibly including some services under the national social health insurance scheme.

"Kenya is ready to work closely with WHO, Africa CDC, fellow member states and global partners to unlock the full potential of traditional medicine—ensuring it is safe, well-regulated, evidence-based and culturally grounded—to strengthen health systems and improve health outcomes across Africa," Duale said.

The WHO summit in India provided global context for Kenya's position. According to WHO, traditional medicine remains a major source of care for millions of people worldwide.

Nearly 90 per cent of WHO member states report that between 40 and 90 per cent of their populations use some form of traditional medicine.

"WHO is committed to uniting the wisdom of millennia with the power of modern science and technology to realise the vision of health for all," director general Tedros AGhebreyesus said.

"By engaging responsibly, ethically and equitably, and by harnessing innovation from AI to genomics, we can unlock the potential of traditional medicine to deliver safer, smarter and more sustainable health solutions for every community and for our planet."

WHO said integrating traditional medicine into health systems is critical at a time when health services are under pressure.

Nearly half of the world's population lacks access to essential health services, while more than two billion people face financial hardship when seeking care.

WHO says safe and regulated traditional medicine can help expand access and choice, while supporting prevention and health promotion.

(+) INSTANT ANALYSIS

Kenya is recognised as a Regional Centre of Regulatory Excellence in pharmacovigilance for its leading role in monitoring medicine safety in the region. Duale said technology is helping improve oversight and digital tools and AI are being used to speed up evaluation.

NEWS COUNTIES

POLITICAL REALIGNMENT

Ex-governor Kuti endorses Guyo for second term in Isiolo

JULIUS OTIENO

IN a move that carries political weight and symbolic resonance, Isiolo's immediate former governor, Mohamed Kuti, has publicly endorsed his successor Abdi Guyo's bid for a second term.

During a family reunion in Garbatula, Kuti employed parables to underscore his message, urging the people to "hold with a tight grip the leadership in your possession," a statement widely interpreted as a call to safeguard the current administration and maintain continuity in governance.

He emphasised that sustained leadership under capable stewardship is often the most reliable path to development.

In a subtle but pointed message, Kuti also addressed his withdrawal from frontline politics, saying leadership succession is not abandonment, but a deliberate transfer of trust to a worthy successor.

He explained that his decision was informed by careful observation and mentorship over the years, expressing confidence in Guyo's abilities, asserting that he "only gave the people a man who deserved it".

The endorsement was met with support from county leaders, including Women rep Mumina Bonaya, Isiolo North MP Samal Lomwa, former Isiolo South MP Abdi Koropu and county assembly speaker Abdullahi Banticha, all of whom have publicly aligned themselves with Guyo's re-election bid.

PHOTO STORY

Calla PR account director Njeri Kagera is gifted by the agency's CEO Kevin Otiende in appreciation for her contributions, as the firm marked a milestone with its entry into Tanzania earlier this year /HANDOUT

CLASHES

Dusk-to-dawn curfew imposed in Trans Mara

Lagat gives illegal gun holders 72 hours to surrender weapons or face action

CYRUS OMBATI
@CyrusOmbati

THE government has announced a dusk-to-dawn curfew in Trans Mara East and South in Narok county, following violent clashes that have left seven people dead.

Officials said more than 120 houses have been torched in the tribal clashes and many families displaced.

Deputy Inspector General of Police Eliud Lagat and his Administration Police counterpart Gilbert Masengeli on Saturday designated the areas as security-disturbed and dangerous.

Lagat said the curfew starts from 6 pm as a special operation is ongoing to restore calm.

The areas expected to observe the curfew include Nkararu in Trans Mara west.

In Trans Mara South, areas of Oldonyo-Orok, Siteti, Ololoma, Corner, Ratiki, Isokon, Kerinkani, Kondamet, Olkiloriti, Angata Barakoi, Kapkeres, Lolgorian town, Mashangwa, Sachangwan will observe the curfew.

Lagat gave those holding illegal guns 72 hours to surrender the weapons or face appropriate action.

The latest incident happened Friday night when a driver was shot and killed and many others were wounded after their vehicle was targeted.

In Angata Barakoi, the Kenya Red Cross reported that tribal clashes have displaced over 1,800 people in just three days.

Fighting between the Maasai and Kipsigis communities have left several people dead and property destroyed, including the torching of homes.

Lagat had urged the two communities to co-exist peacefully, warning politicians and individuals inciting and financing the recent fighting.

"We are profiling all those behind the menace and will be coming for them soon," he said.

The latest directives follow a security assessment conducted this morning, led by the two deputy police IGs in the company of other officials from the Ministry of Interior.

During their tour, the two DIGs held a consultative meeting with the local leaders, elders and community members in the pursuit of peace.

Rift Valley regional commissioner Aldi Hassan described the situation as grave, warning that the government would deal firmly with anyone fuelling the violence. The clashes are reportedly linked to a long-standing land boundary overlap dispute, leaving property worth millions of shillings destroyed.

According to the Red Cross, children, women and persons with disabilities are the most affected, with food stores destroyed by fire.

Meanwhile, the government extended a dusk-to-dawn curfew in 13 locations within Marsabit county for 30 days amid ongoing stability concerns in the region.

Interior Cabinet Secretary Kipchumba Murkomen said the curfew will commence from 6:30 pm on December 23, since the areas have been designated as "security-disturbed and dangerous".

"The extension underscores ongoing security concerns, with authorities citing persistent threats to both residents and property in these communities," he noted.

Affected locations include Hillo Gorgora, Hillo Orofa, Hillo Walkite, Hillo Tanzania, Hillo Irress Abamartille, Hillo Gootu, Hillo Tessum Qalicha, Hillo Karray and Hillo Hudda.

Others are Hillo Qoranjido, Hillo Irress Shindia, Hillo Rabaalee and Hillo Godde Haroressa.

BENEFITS OF UNITY

Drop in banditry has enhanced security in North Rift – governor

MATHEWS NDANYI

THERE has been a decline in banditry in the North Rift leading to improved security, Turkana Governor Jeremiah Lomorukai has said.

The Turkana community has enjoyed better relations with their neighbours due to the peace and stability, Lomorukai added, while reaffirming his commitment to service delivery, saying this remains his top priority.

The governor, who was speaking in Lodwar town after the county successfully hosted the ninth Tobong'u Lore Cultural Festival, which was graced by President William Ruto, among other guests.

"The lives and needs of our people are bigger than politics. Even when the President was here, he emphasised the need for leaders to unite," Lomorukai said.

The county boss noted that the welfare and needs of the Turkana people must take precedence over political interests, as he called on leaders to work together in addressing shared challenges, as directed by the President during the festival's opening.

Improved relations have also seen communities in the region enjoy better relations with those across the border with Uganda. These gains were the result of sustained unity among leaders, he said, adding that Turkana would make great strides if leaders unite to drive the development agenda forward.

Lomorukai welcomed development commitments announced by the President during the festival's grand opening, saying they reflected continued national government support for Turkana.

"We want to sincerely appreciate the President. As a county, we will work closely with the national government to ensure development reaches our people across all sectors."

Lomorukai directed all departments to compile and submit lists of development projects implemented over the last two years, noting that the county plans to officially launch completed initiatives in the coming year.

"These projects directly touch on the livelihoods of our people. All leaders will be invited to participate as we account for progress made," he said.

Addressing the climate change–induced drought currently affecting the region, the governor confirmed that a countywide food distribution programme is set to begin.

Neighbouring communities would also benefit from the intervention—as envisioned in Ateker culture.

"Our borders cut across the Ateker community. In the spirit of sharing that defines our culture, the border communities will also be included in this exercise."

The Kimormor initiative, an integrated outreach programme delivering essential services directly to pastoralist communities, would also extend to border areas.

Deputy Governor John Erus said Turkana continues to attract investor interest, thanks to Lomorukai's deliberate efforts to strengthen partnerships and accountability.

"The governor is keen on partnerships and my office exists to facilitate that vision. The county has also committed matching funds to donor-supported programmes to ensure sustainable impact," Erus said.

Kanamkemer MCA James Ikeny reported that the community, which donated land for the establishment of the Ekalees Cultural Centre, was willing to provide additional land for a proposed stadium, to which the President had pledged to pump Sh 900 million.

Turkana Governor Lomurukai during the ninth Tobong'u Lore Cultural Festival in Lodwar /MATHEWS NDANYI

REVERSE HARD-WON GAINS

Seme's five-year fight to keep children in school

Community members and leaders raise concern over proposed Sh3,000 lunch levy

FAITH MATETE
@faymatete

WHAT started as a simple act of kindness – feeding a few hungry children – has now grown into a lifeline for hundreds of vulnerable families in Seme subcounty, even as rising education costs threaten to reverse hard-won gains.

Five years ago, Elly Opondo, the voluntary Director of St Jerome Emiliano Ramula Preparatory School, began offering meals to children who came to school hungry.

He shared the effort on Facebook, attracting support from friends, well-wishers and strangers moved by the images.

Today, the initiative feeds about 250 children every school day, supports dozens through secondary education, empowers teenage mothers with vocational skills, and is building a Level 3 health facility expected to open early next year. As the organisation marked its fifth anniversary, however, the mood was mixed.

Community members and leaders raised concern over a proposed Sh3,000 lunch levy for junior secondary school learners, warning that it could push children out of classrooms.

"Most parents here have five or six children in either primary or junior secondary school," Opondo said during the anniversary forum.

He added, "If you force them to pay Sh3,000, many children will be sent home to look for money instead of learning."

Feeding as a foundation for learning At the centre of the initiative is a school feeding programme built on the link between nutrition and education. For the past five years, about

Director Elly Opondo /FAITH MATETE

St Jerome Emiliano Ramula Preparatory School in Seme /FAITH MATETE

250 children from the preparatory school and two neighbouring public schools have received one hot meal a day, five days a week.

The meals are funded through donations from individuals, corporates and well-wishers in Kenya and abroad. The programme costs about Sh40 to Sh45 per child per day, translating to roughly Sh2.3 million annually to run alongside other activities.

"We have seen attendance improve and children concentrate better in class," Opondo said.

He added, "When a child knows they will eat at school, they come and stay."

The programme began after members of the Asian community donated more than Sh300,000 in recognition of Opondo's role in promoting peace after post-election unrest.

The land on which the school operates was donated by his family. But the journey has not been smooth.

Donor fatigue has forced temporary closure in the past, at one point prompting Opondo's mother to sell livestock to keep children fed.

The experience pushed the initiative to rely more on individual donors rather than corporate sponsorships.

The organisation has expanded its work to supplement government efforts in education.

Through bursaries and scholarships, it has supported at least 37 vulnerable learners through secondary school, placing them in institutions such as Ngere Boys, Rang'ala Boys, Ng'iya Girls, Kakamega Boys, Lwak Girls and Butere Girls.

About 35 students have completed their Kenya Certificate of Secondary Education examinations, with the organisation hoping to support some into university, including medical training.

The initiative also runs empowerment programmes for girls and young mothers, particularly teenage mothers, offering tailoring and vocational training to equip them with life skills and income opportunities.

"These are girls who would otherwise be forgotten. If we empower them, we support entire families."

Building on its education and social programmes, the organisation is now constructing a level 3 health facility, funded through donations and expected to become operational by February or March next year.

The facility is intended to provide affordable healthcare services to residents of the surrounding community.

West Seme MCA George Abaja has pledged to push for a water project to support the institution.

VULNERABLE COMMUNITIES

No one will go hungry, CS Ruku tells Kenyans in drought-hit Asals

STEPHEN ASTARIKO

THE government has assured residents of Marsabit county that no Kenyan will die of hunger despite the worsening drought in arid and semi-arid lands counties.

Speaking in Marsabit town during the Tokumma Food and Cultural Festival 2025, Public Service CS Geoffrey Ruku said the government remains fully committed to supporting vulnerable communities hit by the prolonged dry spell, which has followed three consecutive failed rain seasons.

He said drought has severely affected food production, livestock and livelihoods across the region, but emphasised that the government has put measures in place to cushion affected families.

Marsabit is among several Asal counties hardest hit by drought, with thousands of households facing acute food shortages following three successive failed rainy seasons.

"The government is fully committed to ensuring no Kenyan goes hungry, even during periods of drought. The government is fully aware of the challenges our people are facing and will be on round-the-clock to ensure we be there to offer the much-needed assistance to those affected," Ruku said.

He detailed measures, including sufficient national food reserves for vulnerable populations and strong strategies to safeguard livestock, the backbone of local economies.

Ruku also urged local administrators to serve as the government's frontline observers, reporting emerging needs quickly to enable timely emergency responses.

CLOSE COLLABORATION

Cooperation with Ruto has benefitted Kitui, says Malombe

MUSEMBI NZENGU

KITUI county has benefitted from many multimillion-shilling development projects from the national government because of its harmonious cooperation with President William Ruto's administration, Governor Julius Malombe has said.

The governor, elected on the wiper ticket, said close collaboration with the national government had enhanced service delivery.

Malombe said he was committed to sustaining that approach even as he maintained his political allegiance to Wiper. "We are doing what we committed ourselves to do; working for our people. We are using our intellect, networks and connections for the good of our people," the governor said.

He said maintaining an amicable working relationship with Ruto, his deputy, Cabinet secretaries and principal secretaries, among other senior government officials, has helped unlock development opportunities for his county.

Governor Julius Malombe hands over a trophy to Agriculture CEC Stephen Kimwele whose department won during the 2024-25 County Performance Contracting Awards at Kitui TTC grounds on December 19 /MUSEMBI NZENGU

"As the leadership and being the governor of this county we have deliberately decided, as required under the Constitution of Kenya 2010, to work very closely with the national government," he said.

Malombe spoke at Kitui Teachers Training College grounds during the 2024-25 County Performance Contracting Awards Ceremony.

During the event the department of Agriculture and Livestock, under CEC Stephen Kimwele, took the top honours as the best-performing department.

He said as a result of the strong relationship with the national government, Kitui hosted the national Mashujaa Day celebrations last October, an event that significantly boosted development in the county.

According to the county boss, hosting Mashujaa Day led to rehabilitation of Ithookwe Stadium, which hosted the celebrations, as well as the nearby Ithookwe airstrip.

Roads leading to the facilities were recarpeted, while street lighting and pedestrian walkways were installed. He further said a mini State Lodge was constructed in Kitui town, several roads were opened up and others recarpeted, giving the town a more attractive and modern outlook.

Malombe said when Ruto later returned to Kitui in November and spent a day at Kitui Mini State Lodge, he commissioned the tarmacking of several roads.

NEWS COUNTIES

PHOTO STORY

Taita Taveta county assistant resident engineer Lilian Muchiri and water executive Grantone Mwandawiro inspect a project being implemented under the Water and Sanitation Development Project in partnership with the World Bank /HANDOUT

HEALTH RISKS

Western, Nyanza elders reject planned nuclear plant in Siaya

Construction is set to start in Rarieda in 2027 amid safety concerns

HILTON OTENYO
@HiltonOtenyo

ELDERS from Nyanza and Western have rejected the upcoming construction of a nuclear power plant in Siaya county.

Construction of Kenya's first-ever nuclear power plant is set to start in Rarieda subcounty in 2027.

In a statement issued by the Luhya and Luo elders after a consultative meeting in Kakamega on Saturday, the elders said there was no meaningful public and community engagement on a project of such magnitude.

"In view of the likely implications of the nuclear plant to health and the environment in and around the entire Eastern Africa region, the joint council resolved to reject in total the plans of going ahead with the project," the statement said.

Nyanza Professional Caucus chairman George Outa said the government did not take into account the effects of establishing a nuclear power plant right within the Lake Victoria ecosystem.

The elders agreed to establish a technical committee to be headed by engineer Philip Okundi to look into the risks and safety issues of communities living around the lake.

ELDERS AGREED TO ESTABLISH A TECHNICAL COMMITTEE TO LOOK INTO THE RISKS

They said the government did not appreciate the trans boundary nature of Lake Victoria and that a nuclear plant erected in any part of the territorial waters would require the concurrence of other countries, including Uganda, Tanzania, South Sudan, Sudan, Ethiopia, and Egypt.

The elders said the initial plan to have the plant built in Kilifi was abandoned after local communities rejected the idea.

While signing a collaborative MoU with Masinde Muliro University for development of nuclear energy workforce on October 2, Nuclear Power Energy Agency (Nupea) chairman Lawrence Gumbe assured Kenyans of the safety of nuclear energy.

He said the plant's construction is undertaken under the guidance of the International Atomic Energy Agency, which takes into account stringent safeguards.

He said fatalities from nuclear power are at 0.03. Gumbe said the collaboration is a long-term initiative that will include partnerships in carrying out research.

CRISIS

Sugar workers down tools over Sh1.9bn unpaid dues

FAITH MATETE

SUGAR sector workers have started their nationwide strike today following non-payment of salaries and terminal benefits arrears amounting to Sh1.9 billion owed to employees of leased state-owned sugar factories.

The Kenya Union of Sugarcane Plantation and Allied Workers (Kuspaw) said the industrial action will affect Muhoroni, Chemelil, Nzoia and Sony sugar mills.

The workers are demanding that the government releases the funds or provides a clear, time-bound commitment before Christmas.

Kuspaw secretary general Francis Wangara said earlier understandings with the Ministry of Agriculture and the National Treasury on settling the arrears have not yet been implemented. "We were assured that workers' arrears would be paid by November and at the latest before Christmas. There has been no communication, no timeline and no commitment from the government," he said.

The unpaid dues relate to workers who were declared redundant following the leasing of the factories to private operators, as well as employees who were retained by the new millers but are still owed part of their salary arrears and terminal benefits.

According to the union, private investors reduced staff numbers after taking over the mills, leaving many workers without employment and without payment of outstanding dues.

Wangara claimed the union formally wrote to the government on December 15 seeking payment by December 19, noting that failure to meet the deadline would lead to industrial action. We have not received any response. Starting Monday, our members will not report to work until these payments are made," he said. The union urged the new mill operators to respect workers' constitutional right to strike, while maintaining that responsibility for settling the arrears rests with the government.

However, Wangara said any investor willing to pay the workers and later seek reimbursement from the State was free to do so.

"Any company that is ready to pay can go ahead and recover the money from the government," he said.

Wangara said continued silence from the authorities was deepening workers' hardship and undermining confidence among affected employees.

"There is no goodwill or seriousness demonstrated so far. We are not backing down," he said.

On the possibility of legal action, Wangara said the union's immediate priority was engagement with the Ministry of Labour and the transition committees overseeing the leasing process.

136 INTERCEPTED

Donkeys seized amid suspected illegal meat trade

MUSEMBI NZENGU

AUTHORITIES have intercepted 136 donkeys, just two days after the Kitui government sent out an alert over plans to sell donkey meat during Christmas festivities.

It is believed that the herd, whose handlers did not have permits, was being taken to a slaughterhouse.

Director of livestock Joseph Kamonzo said he spotted the donkeys at Mbondoni near Mwingi town along the Thika-Garissa highway.

"I became suspicious about the herd. I therefore sought the assistance of policemen at Mbondoni police station to establish whether the people who were handling the donkey had the requisite documents," he said.

Kamonzo said the four people who were found with the donkeys did not have any permits on them.

"They were, therefore, booked into cells awaiting arraignment in court on Monday," he said.

Kamonzo then handed the animals to Caritas Kitui of Mtunze Punda Akutunze project who hired some young men to take care of the confiscated donkeys until the people found with the animals are presented to court.

Kamonzo said it is not clear where the donkeys came from as the people found with the animals were mean with information.

The suspects first claimed the donkeys were from Nuu in Mwingi Central but later changed the story, saying the animals came from Tseikuru in Mwingi North.

On Thursday livestock executive Stephen Kimwele raised concern over sale of contaminated and uninspected donkey meat being sold to Kitui residents ahead of the festive season.

He urged residents to buy meat only from registered butcheries to avoid consumption of donkey meat.

"As people celebrate Christmas, we want to caution them to ensure they consume only goat meat or beef. In our area, the consumption of donkey meat is prohibited," Kimwele said.

The executive expressed concern that the recent spike in illegal donkey trade and slaughter could significantly reduce Kitui's donkey population, which currently stands at about 160,000.

The intercepted herd of donkeys at Mbondoni police post in Kitui county on Saturday /MUSEMBI NZENGU

★ STAR CLASSIFIED

OUR OFFICES

NAIROBI HEAD OFFICE:
LION'S PLACE, 3rd floor, Waiyaki Way, Westlands, Box: 74497
Tel: 0711046200, 4246200

NAIROBI CBD OFFICE
Portal Place House 3rd Floor Room 310, Muindi Mbingu Street
Tel: 0711046300

MOMBASA OFFICE
TSS Towers, 2nd Floor, Nkrumah Road Mombasa City CBD
Tel: 0711046101 0711046529

ELDORET OFFICE
Laneens Center, Ground Floor, Off Elgeyo Road
Tel: 0790 036671

OFFICE HOURS:
Monday- Friday 8 am to 5 pm
Saturday: 9 am to 12pm

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P.O. Box 648-40100, Kisumu, Tel: 0757090260/0202161934/0722329463 Kisumu - Busia Road, Otonglo
Nairobi Office, High View Lane, Off Ridge Ways Road, P.O Box 17752-00100, Nairobi.
Email: nyaauction@yahoo.com Webmail: info@nyaluoyoauctioneers.com

PUBLIC AUCTION

Duly instructed by the financier we shall sell the listed Motor Vehicle by Public Auction: -

ON 9TH DAY OF JANUARY 2026 AT THE AUCTION CENTRE (TAC) NAIROBI, OFF RIDGE WAYS ROAD, OFF KIAMBU ROAD AT 11.00 AM

VEHICLE MODEL	REG. NO.	LOCATION
TOYOTA PROBOX	KDD 615M	SK DHAHABU
TOYOTA FIELDER	KDL 621P	THE AUCTION CENTRE (TAC)
MERCEDES BENZ	KDS 043L	THE AUCTION CENTRE (TAC)
SHACMAN TRUCK	KBZ 503S	THE AUCTION CENTRE (TAC)
TOYOTA VITZ	KDB 163P	JOYLAND STORAGE YARD

TERMS OF SALE
1. A refundable deposit of Kshs. 100, 000/= to enable you to bid.
2. Cash at the fall of the hammer.

www.nyaluoyoauctioneers.com

EFFATHA AUCTIONEERS

PUBLIC AUCTION

Duly instructed our Principal(s), we shall sell by public auction the under mentioned movable and immovable property(s) together with all the development therein:

ON SATURDAY 31ST JANUARY 2026 AT 10.30AM AT STARTRUCK CAR YARD GROUND, OFFICE A, NEAR TOTAL FOURWAYS KIAMBU ROAD.

PRINCIPAL-VERSUS- ELIZABETH WAMBUI KAMAU(DEBTOR)Re-advertisement
All that property known as **LIMURU/BIBIRIONI/3316** measuring 0.1631(zero decimal one six three one) hectares held on absolute ownership registered in the name of **ELIZABETH WAMBUI KAMAU**

The property is situated within Murengeti shopping centre, Limuru Sub-county within Kiambu County. It is located on the right along Nairobi-Nakuru highway branching through Murengeti Primary school junction and about 300 meters to the East of the said school. The property sits the Embassy Church Murengeti. The coordinates are 1°04'10.5"S and 36°37'44.9"E

PRINCIPAL-VERSUS- STEPHEN MBUTHI NDUNGU(DEBTOR) Re-advertisement
All that property known as **GITHUNGURI/KANJAI/2601** Measuring 0.1631(zero decimal one six three one) hectares held on absolute ownership registered in the name of **STEPHEN MBUTHI NDUNGU**

The property is situated within Kabaka area of Kanjai, Githunguri Sub-county within Kiambu County. It is located approximately 120 meters off and to the left of Githunguri-Ruiru tarmac road deviating at the left-hand road junction about 260 meters after Kabaka palace. The coordinates are 1°03'58.4"S and 36°47'37.6"E

PRINCIPAL-VERSUS- PAULINE WANJIKU KIAMBO (GUARANTOR TO ZACHARIAH GICHIRI)Re-advert
All that property known as **RUIRU/RUIRU EAST BLOCK 2/2987, SUB COUNTY, KIAMBU COUNTY** measuring 0.400Hactares (zero decimal four zero) hectares held on absolute ownership registered in the name of **PAULINE WANJIKU KIAMBU**.
The property is situated within Magomano Kimbo area of Juja sub county off and to the right of Thika superhighway deviating at Kimbo shopping center through Matangi road.

PRINCIPAL-VERSUS- MAURICE MBEJA OCHORI (GUARANTOR TO FAITH WAITHIRA) re-advert
All that property known as **KIJABE/KIJABE BLOCK 1/7302** Measuring 0.467 acres held on absolute ownership registered in the name of **MAURICE MBEJA OCHORI.**

The property is situated within Mai Mahiu Township of Naivasha Sub-county within Nakuru County. It is located approximately 250 meters off and to the right of MaiMahiu-Naivasha tarmac road deviating at the righ-hand road junction about 550 meters after from the Township . There sit a three bedroom house and the property has a brick fence and a gate.

Conditions of sale
- The sales being *'AS-IS-WHERE-IS-BASIS'*, All the interested purchasers are required to view the Properties and verify the details for themselves as these are not warranted by the Auctioneers or the Principal.
- The sale is subject to a reserve price and the seller's right to bid.
- The detailed bidding terms and conditions of sale are available at our offices and viewing of the Properties can be done with prior arrangements.

BUSINESS

CONSULTANT Are you in need of consultancy services? We assist students in preparation of term papers, proposal writing, CVs etc. For more details call 0783007229/0721654622 or email: escatmi2020@gmail.com

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PERSONAL AND PRIVATE TUTOR in business and computer studies both secondary/colleges in kisumu details 0716462733 071395713

JOBS

TEACHERS, NURSES Lawyers and Accountants earn 60000 part time work4 only 2hrs aday twice a week From 5pm to 7pm.col0769150870.

Vibrant Auctioneers

PUBLIC AUCTION

Duly instructed by our principal we shall sell the under mentioned motor vehicles on 30th **December 2025, 10.00 A.M.** **at our offices NURICK BUSINESS CENTRE.**

	Vehicle Make	Vehicle Model	Year	Reg Number	Location
1	Toyota	Passo	2015	KDD426N	Top Rides Thika Rd
2	Mazda	Demio	2012	KCU532X	Carbarn Kiambu Rd
4	Suzuki	Swift	2014	KDE487B	Top Rides Thika Rd
6	Nissan	Lafesta	2017	KDQ856R	Plus Point Kiambu Rd
7	Nissan	Sylphy	2015	KDH894Y	Top Rides Thika Rd
8	Subaru	Outback	2018	KDT847Z	Plus Point Kiambu Rd
9	Suzuki	Wagon R	2016	KDN602E	Plus Point Kiambu Rd
10	Suzuki	Alto	2017	KCP488M	Plus Point Kiambu Rd
11	Volvo	S60	2017	KDQ219S	Plus Point Kiambu Rd
12	Nissan	March	2013	KDC673H	Top Rides Thika Rd
13	Toyota	Harrier	2016	KDN719F	Plus Point Kiambu Rd
14	Subaru	Forester	2015	KDH041C	Plus Point Kiambu Rd
15	Toyota	Axio	2014	KDG415A	Plus Point Kiambu Rd
16	Nissan	Murano		KCE394K	Valuers storage yard

CONDITIONS OF SALE
1 .Viewing to be done at the YARD to verify details as these are not warranted by the Auctioneer or our client.
2. Vehicles are sold on " AS IS WHERE IS BASIS".
3.Cash at the fall of hammer.

PUBLIC NOTICE

THE PHYSICAL & LAND USE PLANNING ACT (No. 13 of 2019)
CHANGE OF USER

The owner of plot **RUIRU EAST/BLOCK 1/375** located at **Kamakis,Ruiru Sub-County** is proposing to change its use from **Agricultural to light industrial-storage go downs** subject to approval by the County Government of Kiambu. Individuals, Institution and any other interested parties with any material objection to the proposed development are requested to forward them in Writing within Fourteen (14) days of this notice to:

CECM-LANDS, HOUSING AND PHYSICAL PLANNING,
COUNTY GOVERNMENT OF KIAMBU,
P.O BOX 2344-00900,
KIAMBU.

R.P.P DANIEL KABIRU -0321

GINEY GEN MERCHANTS AUCTIONEERS

Singh Chal Building, 2nd floor, suite 4 St Mary Assuption Road Off Nbi-Nks
Po Box 12585-20100 Nakuru. Mobile: 0727-379620/0735-585053
EMAIL: gineyauctioneers@gmail.com

PUBLIC AUCTION

Duly instructed by our principal, the financier, we shall sell the under mentioned motor vehicles by public auction on
Monday 12th January 2026 at 11.00 A.M

NO	CLIENT NAME	NO. PLATE	TYPE OF M/V	TO BE VIEWED AND SOLD
1	GEOFFREY MARITIM	KBX 574X	TOYOTA WISH	LEGACY STORAGE YARD NAKURU
2	JEREMIAH REIMOI CHEPKONGA	KCK 894F	NISSAN EXTRAIL	LEGACY STORAGE YARD NAKURU

CONDITION OF SALE
1. Sale subject to reserve price.
2. Cash at the fall of the hammer.
3. Sale is as it is basis.

Manager.

WANTED: Salonist, hoteliers, housekeeper, maids, cleaners, train& employ Local inter, NBI, MSA, Gilo, NKR Reg fee is a MUST details sms only +254722703706

JOBS APPLY land sales agent's marketers, NKR, Gilgil area REG fee is a MUST SMS only for details 0722703706

TRAINED HOUSE KEEPER house help shamba boy nation wide available part time full time sms 0722115384

JOBS apply land sales agent's marketers, NKR,Gilgil area REG fee MUST SMS only for details 0722703706

SALONIST, hoteliers, housekeeper, maids,cleaners, train&employ Local inter,NBI,MSA,Gilo,NKR Reg fee MUST details sms only +2547227037

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PUBLIC NOTICE

THE LAND REGISTRATION ACT
LOST CERTIFICATE OF TITLE

WHEREAS we **CISCOS KENYA LIMITED**, of P.O. Box 623-00600 in the Republic of Kenya, is registered as proprietor lessee of all that piece of land known as L.R. No. 330/560 (ORG NO. 330/277/1). Situated at Lavington, and whereas the reconveyance and original Title Deed has been lost, notice is given to the members of public hereof that, The proprietor will be applying for new provisional certificate of title provided that no objection has been received.

Dated the 19th December, 2025

PUBLIC NOTICE

Physical and Land Use Planning Act No. 13 of 2019

CHANGE OF USER

The registered owners of **KWALE/DIANI/5953,** wishes to change user from **Agricultural** to **Residential (Multi-dwelling Units),** subject to County approval. Individuals, institutions, members of the public etc., with comments and/or objections to the proposal are requested to forward them in writing within 14 Days of this notice to:

The CECM – Environment and Natural Resources, Kwale County Government, P.O. Box 4 – 80403, Kwale.

DEATH AND FUNERAL ANNOUNCEMENT

HON. CYRUS SHAKHALAGA KHWA JIRONGO, EGH

The family of **Hon. Cyrus Shakhalaga khwa Jirongo, EGH**, is deeply saddened to announce his sudden passing on the morning of December 13, 2025.

He is the son of the late Paul Jirongo and the late Selina Ikonanga Jirongo.

He is survived by his wives Anne Kanini, Christine Nyokabi, Ann Lanoi, his children, grandchildren, and extended family.

Brother to the late Samson Indoshi, Alfayo Shimbiro, Zipporah Ingefu, Mary Khaendekha, the late David Likhakhasi, Esther Injete, Rebecca Mudeizi, late Nathan Shisanya, Gladys Khamete, Rose Isausi, Grace Shiviangu.

Son in law to the late Jackson Nzioka and Blanche Nzioka, the late Walter Kimani and the late Grace Nyambura and the late Stephen and the late Virginia Pertet.

Hon. Jirongo lived a prolific and eventful life spanning **64 years**, more than half of which were devoted to public service and enterprise. He served the people of **Lugari Constituency** as Member of Parliament for two non-consecutive terms and also held office as **Minister for Rural Development**.

A central figure in Kenya's political history, he was the founding **Chairman of Youth for KANU '92** following the re-introduction of multiparty democracy in 1990. He later contested the **2017 Presidential Election** and, until his passing, served as **Party Leader of the United Democratic Party (UDP)**.

In business, he was **Chairman of Shiftings Ltd, Shale Investments, Moran Cement and African Mineral House**, with interests in **energy, construction, mining, and agriculture**.

He was educated at **Mang'u High School** and later obtained Higher National Diploma from the **Cambridge College** and an Executive MBA from **Jomo Kenyatta University of Agriculture and Technology**

Funeral planning and arrangements:

Family and members of his funeral committee are meeting daily from **4.00 p.m.** at United Kenya Club in Nairobi. Other meetings are being held in Whispers Gigiri, Nairobi, Maili Saba, Kitale and Lumakanda in Lugari.

A 4-day funeral programme has been laid out for the final journey of the late **Hon. Cyrus Shakhalaga khwa Jirongo, EGH**, culminating in burial at his rural home in **Lumakanda, Lugari**.

A **memorial service** will be held at **10.00 am on Saturday, 27th December 2025**, at **Christ Is the Answer Ministries (CITAM), Valley Road**, Nairobi, followed by an overnight vigil at the family residence in **Gigiri, Nairobi**.

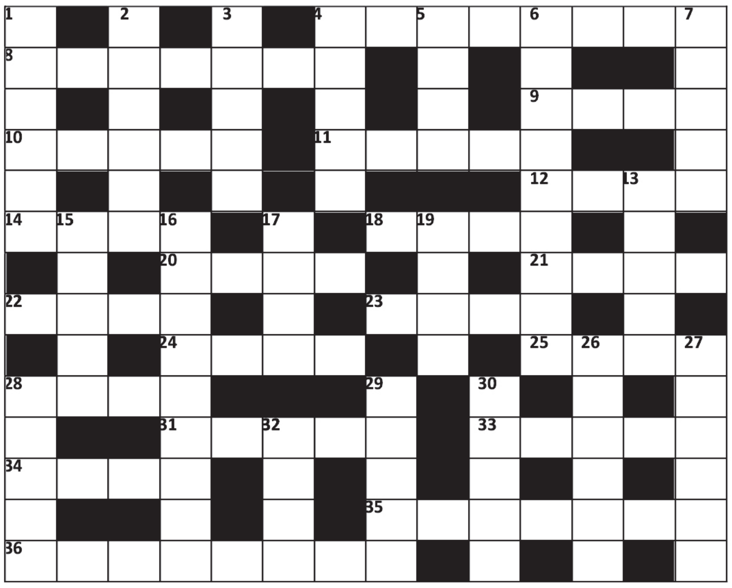
A **service and vigil** will held on **Sunday, 28th December 2025**, at his **Kitale home**, ahead of transfer to Lugari on **29th December 2025.**

Burial will be held on Tuesday, 30th December 2025, at Lumakanda, Lugari.

"Naked I came from my mother's womb, and naked I will return there. The LORD gives, and the LORD takes away. May the name of the LORD be blessed!"

COFFEE BREAK

CROSSWORD / PUZZLE



DOWN
1. A plug for a bunghole in a cask (6)
2. Everything you own; all of your assets and liabilities (6)
3. Former Member of Parliament for Ganze constituency (5)
4. Positive electrode of an electron tube (5)
5. Former Member of Parliament for Mandera South constituency (4)
6. A mirror whose reflecting surface is a part of a hollow sphere of glass (9)
7. Member of Parliament for Emuria Dikirr constituency (5)
13. The male reproductive cell (5)
15. Expel from a country (5)
16. Disease caused due to excess of iron in blood (9)
17. Unit of length (4)
19. Member of Parliament for Kilifi North constituency (4)
26. Cause to occur rapidly (6)
27. Former Member of Parliament for Lurambi constituency (6)
28. He stated the law that the pressure of a given mass of gas is inversely proportional to its volume at constant temperature (5)
29. the one-word name for a negatively charged ion (5)
30. Member of Parliament for Budalangi constituency (5)
32. Hoop that covers a wheel (4)

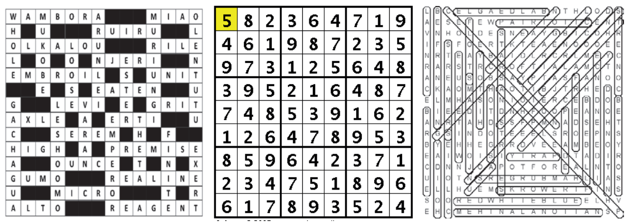
ACROSS
4. physical process by which the particles of different substances stick together (8)
8. Third series in the spectrum of hydrogen (7)
9. An opening into or through something (4)
10. Pictorial representation of the variation of one quantity with respect to another (5)
11. Cabinet Secretary of Health of Kenya (5)
12. Member of Parliament for Saku constituency (4)
14. Starting places for holes on a golf course (4)
18 Member of Parliament for Kuria West constituency (4)
20. Hotels providing overnight lodging for travellers (4)
21 A professional cook (4)
22 Responsible for one's thoughts and feelings (4)
23. Large (4)
24. Reflected sound (4)
25. Former Member of Parliament for Kipkelion East constituency (4)
28. A general name for alcoholic beverages 4)
31. Many times at short intervals (5)
33. Republic in Southern Asia (5)
34. edible roots (4)
35. A medium through which light can pass (7)
36. Developer of the theory of relativity (8)

SUDOKU / SIMPLE

	1	2		8		5		
		7	6		5			
					7	1		
	6				4		1	7
7	3		1				8	
		9	8					
			9		1	4		
		5		4		2	3	

Fill the grid with digits so that each column, each row, and each of the sub-grids that compose the grid all contain all of the numbers from 1 to 9 one time.

Weeekend solutions



WORD SEARCH

Find and mark all the words hidden inside the box. The words may be placed horizontally, vertically, or diagonally.

D C B C C A M D K C O F A S R
N E O O A O N Y O I R G S D Y
E T Y N E E M M T I N E I H L
I A F F L V R P E I N S T M L
R M R I A A I N A E N A H A A
F M I D D M D T S N P I F I E
L O E E B L I O R M I F F R P
R O N U I P L T Y O E O A F T
I R D N E C A S Y C P H N S A
G D E L O Y A L T Y S P U R R
Y S G O O D T I M E S R U I O
S C H U M H O N E S T Y F S V
E C N A T N I A U Q C A U E A
Y H T A P M E S S E N D N O F

ACQUAINTANCE
AFFECTION
AFFINITY
ALLY
AMIGO
AMITY
BOYFRIEND
BUDDY
CHUM
CLOSENESS
COMPANION
COMRADE
CONFIDE
EMPATHY
FAVOR
FONDNESS
FRIENDLINESS
FUN
GIRLFRIEND
GOOD TIMES
HONESTY
KINSHIP
LEND
LOYALTY
PAL
ROOMMATE
SHARE
SUPPORTIVE
SYMPATHY
TRUST

ALL IN THE STARS

CAPRICORN
December 22 – January 20

You've made it over the hump. You've moved beyond the problems of the recent past and you're entering a more peaceful phase.

AQUARIUS
January 21 – February 19

Why not plan a little trip? All signs indicate that this is the best time to plan such an adventure.

PISCES
February 20 – March 20

This will be a day rich in reflection. You're able to observe what's going around you while still retaining some distance.

ARIES
March 21 – April 20

Here's a day when some long-awaited attention or recognition comes your way.

TAURUS
April 21 – May 21

You've entered a period of rethinking both your identity and objectives. These aren't small matters.

GEMINI
May 22 – June 21

This would be an ideal day to take extra care of your body. Don't kid yourself that those back problems will go away.

CANCER
June 22–July 22

Pay special attention to the choices you've made in your profession. Are you sure you're doing what you were meant to do? Are you using your talents to the fullest?

LEO
July 23 – August 22

This will be a great day to meditate. You may be dissatisfied because your various projects have yet to take form.

VIRGO
August 23 – September 23

Continued efforts to stabilize your behavior will provide the security you desire for the future.

LIBRA
September 24 – October 23

Although certain details in your love life still need to be worked out, it's safe to coast for a while.

SCORPIO
October 24 – November 22

Today don't ignore any urge you feel for solitude. Even though it's an unusual need for you, it's still valid and you should honor it.

SAGITTARIUS
November 23 – December 21

Sometimes friends become your real family. Your friendships are deeper and more enduring than you realize.

ODDLY ENOUGH

German engineer becomes first wheelchair user to go to space

BBC/ An engineer from Germany has become the world's first wheelchair user to go into space.

Michaela Benthaus, who suffered a spinal cord injury in a mountain bike accident seven years ago, had reached out to a retired space engineer online to see if her dream of being an astronaut was still possible. He then helped organise the historic 10-minute flight with Blue Origin, the space tourism company founded by Jeff Bezos.

Benthaus and five others blasted off from Texas on Saturday and reached a point just above the so-called "boundary" of space, known as the Kármán line.

"It was the coolest experience!" she said after landing in a video shared by Blue Origin. "I didn't only like the view and the micro-gravity, but I also liked going up. That was so cool, every stage of going up." New Shepard, Blue Origin's reusable sub-orbital launch vehicle, took off from the company's Texas launch pad at 14:15 GMT.

Benthaus, who works at the European Space Agency, said she had "really, really figured out how inaccessible our world still is" for people with disabilities following her accident. She made her own way from her wheelchair into the capsule, using a bench extending from the hatch.

Hans Koenigsmann, the retired SpaceX manager who helped organise the trip, was strapped in nearby to offer assistance during the flight if needed.

TELEVISION LINEUP – MONDAY

tv47

5:00AM	MORNING DECREE	7:00PM	UPEO WA TV47
5:30AM	TV47 FITNESS	7:30PM	MINT
6:00AM	MORNING CAFÉ'	8:00PM	DW DOCUFILM
10:00AM	TV47 MATUKIO	8:30PM	FALLING INTO YOUR SMILE
2:00PM	BAZE 47	9:00PM	THE DAILY REPORT WITH ABUBAKAR
3:00PM	KILIMO DIARIES - RPT	10:00PM	ABDULLAHI
3:30PM	NUZO AND NAMIA (ENGLISH)	12:00 AM	90+
4:00PM	TV47 NEWS NOW	2:00AM	BEATPLUG MIX
4:15PM	BEAT BREAK	3:00AM	DW DOCUFILM RPT
4:30PM	KIKI AND NUNA	4.00AM	WILD KINGDOM
5:00PM	BEATPLUG		
6:00PM	LA MUJER DE JUDAS		

SPORTS

SPORTS LOCAL

SWIMMING

Zac lifts Riptide Club to victory at Chipkizi show in Arusha

BY WILLIAM NJUGUNA

Zac Okumu led Riptide Swimming Club to overall glory at the 2025 East African Chipkizi Swimming Championship, which was held at Braeburn School, Arusha, over the weekend.

Okumu delivered one of the standout performances of the meet in the Boys 14–15 years 100 metres freestyle, clocking an impressive 58.68 seconds—one of the fastest times recorded at the championship and a swim that drew praise from coaches and competitors alike.

Riptide Swim Club dominated the combined team standings, amassing a commanding 3,014 points to finish top overall. They were followed by Mwanza Swim Club with 2,600 points, while Lake Victoria Sports Club placed third on 2,200 points.

Several young swimmers also caught the eye with outstanding individual displays. In the Girls 8–9 years category, Rune Klenz impressed in the 25-metre backstroke, touching the wall in 23.89 seconds to underline the value of early technical development in swimming.

In the same age group, Massawe Aika of North Coast Swimming Club showcased her potential by winning the 50 metres butterfly in 47.83 seconds, controlling the race with smooth turns and measured pacing.

Rune Klenz of Riptide School in action at the East Africa Chipkizi Championship in Arusha/**HANDOUT**

Speaking after the championship, Khalid Yahya-Rushaka OLY, head coach of North Coast Swimming Club in Dar es Salaam, praised the organisers—PIPSSA Kenya, Genesis Sports Limited and Ripples Sports—for delivering a well-run and exciting gala.

Rushaka described the championship as a vital platform for exposing young talent and building confidence among developing swimmers. He noted that several teams withdrew at the last minute due to recent political instability in the region, but reassured stakeholders that Tanzania remains stable and safe.

ATHLETICS

COURSE CHANGED

Tinderet organisers seek to align with international standards

Philemon Kiriago crosses the finish-line during the World Mountain and Trail Running Championships in Spain/**GICHANA ANGWENYI**

BY ANGWENYI GICHANA

Organisers of the annual Tinderet Barng'etuny Mountain Run have revamped the race course in a move aimed at aligning the event with international mountain running standards.

The Local Organising Committee (LOC) secretary Peter Sang confirmed on Sunday that the senior men's and women's races have been extended to 21 kilometres, up from the traditional 14km distance.

The revised course will start and finish at the same venue. The 2026 edition, scheduled for January 17 at Lions Hill Farm in Tinderet, Nandi County, will also introduce several new race categories as organisers seek to grow the event's profile and competitive depth.

Registration for the race has already opened. "Previously, we had a 14km classic race. However, we have decided to upgrade to a 21km up-and-down course to meet international standards," Sang said.

In another first, the organisers have introduced a 4km junior race for under-20 athletes, a move Sang says is intended to nurture the next generation of mountain runners.

Sang, who served as team manager for Kenya at the World Mountain and Trail Running Championships in Canfranc, Spain, said the decision was influenced by performances witnessed at the global event.

"During the World Mountain and Trail Running Championships, Uganda dominated the junior races. In future events, we want to challenge them," he said.

The programme will also feature a 500m race for boys and girls aged 5–7 years, as well as a 1km race for children aged 8–12 years. Organisers expect more than 2,000 athletes to take part. "Online registration for the senior and junior races has already started.

With the introduction of the junior categories, we expect the numbers to rise. Preparations for the race are in top gear," Sang added.

He noted that technical officials from Athletics Kenya are expected to design the final course on Monday. World Mountain and Trail Running champion Philemon Kiriago has already confirmed his participation in the race.

Athletics Kenya Mountain Running coordinator Peter Angwenyi commended the organisers—led by race patron and Tinderet MP Julius Melly—for their consistency in staging the event.

"This is the fifth edition of the race. The Tinderet Barng'etuny Mountain Run is now the most popular mountain race in the country and has become a household name in mountain running," Angwenyi said.

He added that the event has, over the years, attracted top mountain runners and played a key role in identifying and nurturing emerging talent.

FOOTBALL

Vehicles, glory and dreams as Abbas Khalif Super Cup tournament ends in style

BY CHARLENE MALWA

When the final whistle sounded at the inaugural Abbas Khalif Super Cup, it did more than crown champions.

It sparked celebrations, stirred fresh ambitions—and introduced an unusual dilemma rarely associated with local football tournaments: what to do with the vehicles that came with victory.

For three of the standout teams at the 2025 edition, success arrived with keys in hand. As medals were packed away and trophies lifted, debates quickly emerged within camps.

Should the vehicles be retained to ease team logistics and transport players to league fixtures, or should they be sold and the proceeds shared among squad members as a more immediate reward?

The discussion has added a curious postscript to a tournament already rich in drama. At the heart of the story were South C Rangers, who wrote themselves into the competition's history books by claiming the top prize—a 33-seater bus—after edging State City 1–0 in a tense final.

The defining moment came in the 58th minute when slight-built forward Ali Maleche exploited a rare defensive lapse, chesting down a cross before firing an unstoppable shot into the far corner.

State City pushed hard in response, creating a flurry of chances as they hunted for an equaliser, but poor finishing undermined their efforts. Rangers, meanwhile, could have made the outcome more comfortable, missing two clear opportunities that would have put the contest beyond doubt.

Though beaten, State City were not left empty-handed. They drove away with a 14-seater vehicle, matching the reward earned by Kuwinda, who delivered a commanding 3–0 victory over Akiba in the third-place playoff.

Beyond the prizes, the tournament served as a platform for individual excellence. Kevin Masongo of South C Rangers emerged as Goalkeeper of the Tournament, keeping five clean sheets to anchor his side's title charge.

Match-winner Ali Maleche was deservedly named Most Valuable Player, while John Wambua of Kuwinda finished as Golden Boot winner after scoring seven goals.

For Maleche, the recognition carries deeper meaning than silverware or accolades. The Division Two forward sees the tournament as a gateway to bigger opportunities.

"This tournament has been very competitive, and hopefully the many coaches from top clubs have seen what we have done as a team and what I can do as a player," Maleche said.

"I want to keep improving, get a bigger platform and, one day, play and score for the national team."

Wambua shares similar aspirations, viewing his goal-scoring exploits as a chance to step onto a larger stage. "Scoring is what I enjoy doing," he said.

"If bigger clubs come for my services, I will gladly take that chance. The defenders here were tough, but I still managed to find ways past them."

As the dust settles on a compelling first edition, the Abbas Khalif Super Cup has ticked many boxes—competitive matches, emerging talent and tangible rewards that go beyond medals.

Whether the winning vehicles remain long-term team assets or are converted into shared spoils, the tournament has already made a statement. In its debut year, it has not only crowned champions but also firmly established itself in the local football calendar—leaving behind stories that extend well beyond the pitch.

South C Rangers receive their award after winning the Abbas Super Cup trophy/ **HANDOUT**

RUGBY

PREPARATIONS INTENSIFY

Shujaa set for Stellenbosch camp ahead of WorldSevens Division Two

BY WILLIAM NJUGUNA

KENYA Sevens will embark on a 10-day high-performance training camp in Stellenbosch, South Africa, in mid-January as part of their preparations for the start of the World Rugby Sevens Division Two series, which kicks off on February 14–15 at Nyayo Stadium, Nairobi.

Kenya Rugby Union (KRU) had initially considered entering the team into a competitive tournament early in the new year, but the plan was shelved due to the proximity of the Division Two opener and the logistical demands involved.

Speaking over the weekend, KRU chief executive officer Thomas Odundo said the South African camp offered a more practical and effective alternative, allowing the team to play high-intensity matches against quality opposition at a lower cost.

“We had to weigh the cost implications involved in travelling for a tournament, where there is also a high probability of players getting injured,” said Odundo.

“Recovery time would be minimal with just a month left to the start of the series, so the camp made more sense.”

Odundo noted that the Stellenbosch camp will be critical in sharpening the squad and improving various facets of play ahead of the physically demanding second-tier series.

“The camp will be vital in upskilling the players and ensuring they are in the right frame for the rigours of the Division Two competition,” he added.

“It will also be an eye-opener as we assess different aspects of the team to ensure the players are well-positioned and ready for the start of the series.”

With Kenya hosting the opening leg in Nairobi, Odundo stressed the importance of a strong start.

“By virtue of us hosting the first tournament, a good start will be key in building momentum heading into the second and third legs in Uruguay and Brazil,” he observed.

The men’s side, Shujaa, will be joined at the Stellenbosch camp by the Kenya Lionesses, with both teams targeting promotion to the top tier of the World Rugby Sevens Series at the end of the season.

In the men’s Division Two competition, Kenya will face the USA, Germany and Uruguay, alongside two teams promoted from Division Three, which will be contested in Dubai in January.

The Lionesses will take on China, Spain and Brazil, as well as two Division Three sides emerging from the Dubai event.

At the end of the final round in Brazil, the top four teams from both the men’s and women’s Division Two competitions will advance to a three-leg championship series featuring 12 teams—eight from the top tier and four from Division Two.

The final championship events will be staged in Hong Kong,

William Mwanji fends off a Zambian opponent during the Africa Cup Sevens held in Mauritius early this year/**HANDOUT**

DARTS

Munyua stays focused ahead of Dutch Doets tie at World Championships

BY TEDDY MULEI

Kenyan darts sensation David Munyua will be hoping to extend his flying form at the PDC World Darts Championship at the Alexandra Palace stage today (Monday) when he takes on Dutchman Kevin Doets in the second round of the global show.

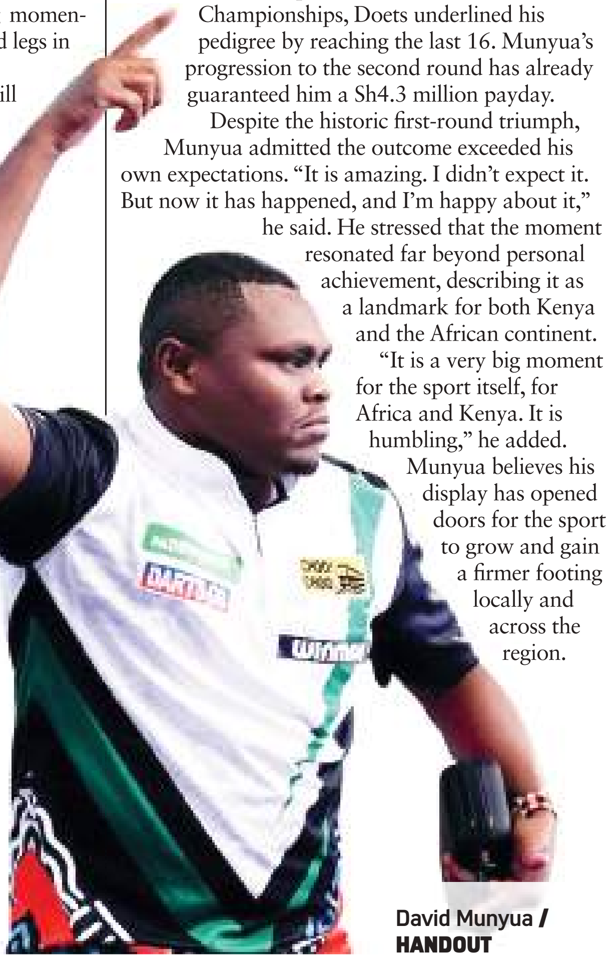
Munyua unequivocally announced himself last Thursday, producing a stunning comeback from two sets down to outgun world number 18 Mike De Decker 3-2 in the opening round.

The 30-year-old veterinarian now faces another stern examination against world number 41 Doets, a seasoned campaigner with a formidable resume. The Dutchman boasts victory at the 2019 Catalonia Open under the British Darts Organisation (BDO) banner and has claimed two PDC Challenge Tour titles. At the previous edition of the World Championships, Doets underlined his pedigree by reaching the last 16. Munyua’s progression to the second round has already guaranteed him a Sh4.3 million payday.

Despite the historic first-round triumph, Munyua admitted the outcome exceeded his own expectations. “It is amazing. I didn’t expect it. But now it has happened, and I’m happy about it,” he said. He stressed that the moment resonated far beyond personal achievement, describing it as a landmark for both Kenya and the African continent.

“It is a very big moment for the sport itself, for Africa and Kenya. It is humbling,” he added.

Munyua believes his display has opened doors for the sport to grow and gain a firmer footing locally and across the region.



David Munyua / **HANDOUT**

ATHLETICS

Omanyala bullish as he predicts strong Kenyan sprint display in 2026 season

BY TEDDY MULEI

Africa’s fastest man, Ferdinand Omanyala, believes the Betika BingwaFest is the ideal sharpening ground for Kenya’s sprinters as they gear up for a packed and demanding 2026 calendar year.

Omanyala was speaking after lining up at the BingwaFest Central Region edition over the weekend at Kinoru Stadium, where he featured in the men’s 4x100m relay.

Running alongside his Achievers Sprint Club training mates Steve Odhiambo, Isaac Omurwa and Samuel Chege, the quartet stopped the clock at 40.0 seconds to finish third.

Utawala Sprints Club dominated the event, with the quartet of Richard Ogutu, Meshack Babu, Ronald Koech and Simani Reguu storming to victory in 39.3 seconds. KDF’s team of Wiseman Were, Justin Isaboke, Brian Tinega and Boniface Mweresa followed closely, clocking 39.6 for second place.

Omanyala underlined the value of BingwaFest in fine-tuning speed, rhythm and race sharpness among the country’s sprinters.

“I am happy to be here for the Meru edition of BingwaFest, and I really appreciate this platform for my fellow sprinters,” said the 2022 Commonwealth champion.

He noted that the 2025 season had already delivered encouraging signs, with Kenyan sprinters posting faster and more competitive times. “This was a significant development for the season, as we saw many better times posted by sprinters,” he observed.

Sprinters during the BingwaFest Central region edition/ **HANDOUT**

Omanyala also called for an expanded competition calendar to keep athletes race-ready and continually improving. “As sprinters, we need more competitions so that we can better our times. This is a great initiative, and I urge more sprinters to continue working hard and showing up,” he added.

Meanwhile, Loice Chemnung stole the spotlight in the distance events, completing a superb long-distance double by winning both the women’s 10,000m and 5,000m races. The 28-year-old clocked 32:07.7 in the 10,000m before returning to the track to post 15:22.4 in the 5,000m.

Chemnung walked away with a total of Sh550,000 in prize money, Sh300,000 for the 10,000m victory and Sh250,000 for triumphing in the 5,000m. She paid tribute to her coach, Thomas Potzinger, for encouraging her to attempt the demanding double.

“I am happy to have won both the 10,000m and 5,000m races. Initially, I had planned to compete only in the 10,000m, but my coach encouraged me to run the 5,000m as well. It was very encouraging seeing him guide me throughout both races at every corner of the field,” Chemnung said.

In the men’s 10,000m, Mathew Kipkoech emerged victorious after clocking 28:44.2, edging out Justus Lelinton (28:44.7) and Amos Langat (28:45.2).

Miriam Cherop claimed the women’s 1,500m, clocking 4:18.4 ahead of Josephine Sembeyo (4:19.2) and Vivian Chebet (4:19.4).

In the men’s race, Dominic Bargentuny claimed top honours in 3:40.4, followed by Ng’eno Kipngetich (3:41.1) and Mathew Kipsang (3:41.8).

Veteran sprinter Milcent Ndoro showcased her enduring class by winning both the women’s 100m and 400m races. She stormed to victory in the 100m in 11.6 seconds, ahead of Neviah Michira (12.2) and Jane Mirigo (12.3), before returning to dominate the 400m in 55.4 seconds. Martha Nyabuto (55.9) and Moreno Wafula (56.4) completed the podium.

PREMIER LEAGUE

IS IT GUNNERS' TURN THIS SEASON?

What does it mean to be top and bottom on Christmas Day?

BY CHRIS COLLINSON

BBC SPORT STATISTICIAN

ARSENAL will spend Christmas Day on top of the Premier League tree this year, while Wolves, Burnley and West Ham are hanging precariously on the bottom branches.

As we approach the halfway point of the season, what do the ghosts of Christmas past tell us about the title race and relegation battle?

The title race

The team that is top of the Premier League on Christmas Day has gone on to win the title in 17 of the previous 33 seasons – basically a flip of a chocolate coin. However, Arsenal themselves have a much bleaker record as they've been top at Christmas four times before but have never gone on to lift the trophy.

The Gunners had only been top at this stage twice before Mikel Arteta took charge, but this is the third time in four seasons that they sit top of the tree at Christmas.

Their fans will hope that the wisdom Arteta's men have received in seasons past will see them finally hold off Manchester City and deliver the gift they've been wishing for since 2004.

"You'd like to think that through all the experiences that Arsenal have had being top at Christmas, they can understand the mistakes made in the back half of some seasons that stopped them from winning the title," former Manchester City defender Nedum Onuoha told Football Focus.

There isn't a lot of room for error, though, as Arsenal have a slender lead of just two points, while the average lead by the team top on Christmas Day is four points.

In fact, the only table-toppers at Christmas to have a smaller lead than Arsenal in the last 12 seasons were the Gunners themselves two years ago.

But while a two-point lead isn't much, history suggests it might be enough. Arsenal are the eighth side in Premier League history to have a two-point lead at Christmas and five of the previous seven went on to win the title, including the last four.

Bizarrely, Arsenal are the only side to win the Premier League without ever doing it when they were top at Christmas, as all three of their titles came when chasing the leaders at this time of year.

They were sixth and an incredible 13 points behind leaders Man United in 1997-98, second and three points behind Newcastle in 2001-02 and third and one point behind Man Utd at Christmas time in 2003-04.

That 13-point deficit in 1997-98 is the most points a team has ever been behind the leaders at Christmas and won the title (Arsenal did have a game in hand), while the lowest the eventual champions have been in the table at this stage is eighth, by Manchester City in the Covid-delayed season of 2020-21.

Weirdly, the team in second on Christmas Day has gone on to win the title in only two of the past 17 seasons, although both times it was Manchester City who did so.

In fact, in the last five seasons where the leaders at Christmas did not go on to win the title, the Premier League was won each time by Manchester City.

Will this season be different for Arsenal?

For many Arsenal fans, there will be a sense of deja vu. Leading the Premier League at Christmas before being eaten up by a relentless Pep Guardiola side is something the Gunners have got a little bit used to.

Seeing a seven-point lead over Manchester City cut to two in the space of five games won't exactly fill them with confidence either.

"We're back on top of the table, but we're not watching City too much, or the other teams," said Bukayo Saka. "We're in control now. We know if we win every week, we'll stay there."

Arteta added, "The only thing we can control is our own performance and results, and we know how long it's going to be and how tough this league is. That's it."

Manchester City have obviously got history on their side. Guardiola has won the Premier League title six times, the Bundesliga three times with Bayern Munich and La Liga three times with Barcelona. Arteta has no league titles as a manager.

Guardiola's squad are full of Premier League winners, players who know what it takes to end a campaign strongly. In comparison, only Gabriel Jesus among the Arsenal squad has won the Premier League four times in his days as a Manchester City player. Rather than Arsenal being serial winners in recent times, they have experienced losing leads over the past few seasons.

Why can't this season be different, though? Manchester City look far from the relentless side they have been in previous seasons, and have already lost four games this campaign, compared to Arsenal's two losses. "We will be there. If they follow me, we will be there, but we have to improve," said Guardiola.

"I know the level in Europe, in the Premier League, I know Arsenal and the other teams and how tough they are. It is not enough.

"The spirit is there. Last season, we did not have the spirit, aggression or hunger - all the attributes they need. It is not about the highlights and how good the actions are; there is something that comes from inside where we will recover from the Club World Cup."

City's attack is flowing, having scored 10 more goals than Arsenal, but having also conceded six more – you feel the title race could be defined by whether City's goals can outshine Arsenal's solidity.

The relegation battle

Only four times in 33 Premier League seasons has the side at the bottom on Christmas Day survived, with the most recent being Wolves in 2022-23.

Mikel Merino of Arsenal celebrates with teammates after scoring during the English Premier League match /XINHUA

Liverpool's Alexander Isak (2nd L) leaps off the pitch after getting injured against Tottenham on Saturday/XINHUA

Isak's injury in chaotic Liverpool win compounds Slot's problems

BY AADAM PATEL, BBC FOOTBALL REPORTER

It was meant to be the moment that finally kick-started the season for Alexander Isak. Liverpool's £125m signing had come off the bench and finished wonderfully past Tottenham goalkeeper Guglielmo Vicario to give Arne Slot's side the lead.

On the touch-line, Slot was ecstatic after seeing Isak combine with Florian Wirtz, who got his first Premier League assist after signing for £116m in the summer.

With Mohamed Salah in Morocco on Africa Cup of Nations duty and Cody Gakpo out with injury, here was a glimpse of Liverpool's future. And the first sign of a connection between Liverpool's two record signings.

Yet within seconds, that joy turned to concern as Isak lay on the floor in agony after Micky van de Ven's tackle. As his team-mates gathered around him, it became clear that Isak would be unable to continue. "We'll have to wait and see," said Slot. "But if a player scores and then gets injured and doesn't try to come back on the pitch, that's usually not a good thing."

It looks ominous indeed. For Liverpool, who have seemingly turned a corner and are now unbeaten in six, the problems continue to mount, though, with Isak and Conor Bradley both facing a spell on the sidelines.

To sum up their misfortune in a nutshell, Bradley was taken off at half-time after a knock for Isak. On the hour mark, Isak came off for Jeremie Frimpong, who was playing his first game since October.

Frimpong then failed to finish the game as he was replaced by Federico Chiesa in the 90th minute, though Slot insisted that the full-back would be fine and that he simply didn't want to take the risk of playing for 30 seconds with 10 men.

Either way, two players that Slot subbed on failed to finish the game.

In the end, Hugo Ekitike's goal ensured Liverpool held on to yet another crucial victory, but they almost blew it against the nine men of Tottenham, who had both Xavi Simons and Cristian Romero sent off.

"A masterclass on how not to manage the final 10 minutes" was the verdict of Jamie Redknapp on Sky Sports. Slot himself admitted that it was far from ideal.

"It's unbelievable if you play against nine men that I would not be surprised if, for the nine minutes of added time, they had the ball for eight and a half. That is not what you expect, and maybe that tells you where we are in this season," Slot said.

"We need a few more wins to get a bit more comfortable with setbacks. The thing that keeps in your mind is the last 10 minutes, but there was a lot more to like in the first 80 to 90 minutes."

ATHLETICS

Tindiret organisers make changes to meet international stanadrds

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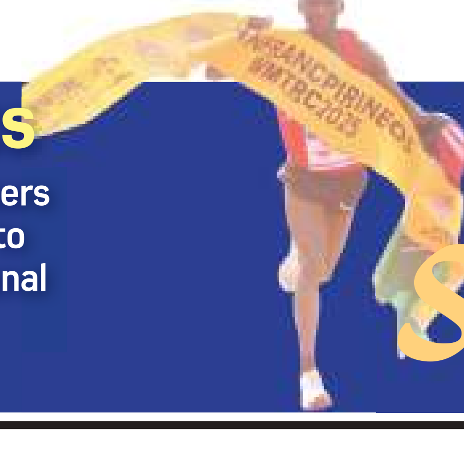

MONDAY, DECEMBER 22, 2025

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ATHLETICS

ACE YEGO NOT DONE YET

Javelin great plots patient road back for 2026 revival following heartbreak at Tokyo Worlds

BY TEDDY MULEI

The 2016 Olympic javelin silver medallist Julius Yego insists he is not exiting the scene just yet, as he plots a strong comeback in 2026 following heartbreak at the Tokyo World Championships.

At 36, Yego remains one of Team Kenya's most seasoned campaigners, boasting appearances at seven World Championships and four Olympic Games.

His finest hour on the global stage came at the 2015 World Championships in Beijing, where he soared to gold with a monstrous African record throw of 92.72m.

The following year, he backed that up with another imperious performance at the Rio Olympic Games, clinching silver with an 88.24m effort.

He finished behind Germany's Thomas Rohler, who unleashed a 90.30m throw to claim gold, while Trinidad and Tobago's Keshorn Walcott completed the podium with bronze at 85.38m.

However, at his seventh World Championships appearance in Tokyo, Yego fell short of recapturing his global crown, his campaign cruelly cut short by injury.

He exited the competition in sixth place with a best mark of 85.54m.

Walcott went on to strike gold with a season-best 88.16m, as Grenada's Anderson Peters (87.38m) and American Curtis Thompson (86.67m) settled for silver and bronze, respectively.

Despite the heartbreak of Tokyo, Yego insists the fire still burns.

He is back in training and laying the groundwork for a calculated push into the 2026 season.

"I am getting ready for next season. After my injury in Tokyo, I came back home and had some rest," Yego said.

Aware of the fine margins that come with recovery, the Kenyan great knows patience will be his greatest ally as he rebuilds.

"I am just putting in the work in training to see how my body responds," he added.

"After the injury I had, it's all about waiting and being patient. I can't rush myself."

Yego further noted that the 2026 calendar year is stacked with competitions, underlining why a measured approach will be key to staying competitive.

"Next year is a long season also, so I have to be careful with my approach to competition and be patient with my training," he said.

His 2025 campaign has been a mixed bag, marked by fluctuating form as he searched for rhythm and consistency.

He opened his season at the Doha Diamond League in May, throwing 78.52m to finish ninth as Germany's Julian Weber (91.06m) and India's Neeraj Chopra (90.23m) dominated first and second.

That was followed by a disappointing 74.71m at the Kip Keino Classic in Nairobi, where Brazil's Luiz Mauricio da Silva triumphed with 86.34m.

But the tide began to turn in June with Yego rediscovering his groove in Europe, winning the Motonet GP in Finland with an 82.95m throw before improving to 83.08m at the Turku Continental meet.

He dipped again at the Paris Diamond League, managing 80.26m for sixth, but quickly bounced back at the inaugural Neeraj Chopra Classic in India, claiming silver with a season-best 84.51m behind Chopra's 86.18m.

In Brussels, he launched 80.50m to finish fifth, before rounding off his Diamond League campaign with another fifth-place finish at the Zurich final, registering an 82.01m throw.

Julius Yego at Tokyo World Champs/XINHUA

Relief for coach Ayany as Naivas FC end seven-game winless run in NSL

Gucha Stars players at Gusii Stadium/ ANGWENYI GICHANA

BY ANGWENYI GICHANA

National Super League side Naivas ended a seven-game winless streak with a 1-0 victory over Talanta, a result their coach Elvis Ayany says will boost the players' confidence.

"The win was a breakthrough for us. We had gone seven games without scoring. It was a huge relief for the boys because they were working hard, creating chances, but not finishing. The win meant a lot for the players—you could see it from the celebrations," Ayany said. Former Nairobi City Stars striker David Agesa scored the lone goal for Naivas, and he echoed his coach's sentiments.

"It was a very important win. We have redeemed ourselves and will come back stronger after the Christmas break. We are ready to push on," Agesa said. Ayany is optimistic about the league resuming on January 10. "The boys are now motivated. We are back on track. I believe the rough patch is behind us," he noted.

For Talanta, coach Jack Gatheru attributed the loss to fixture congestion. "We have played four games in eight days, travelling to Mombasa and Kisumu. This led to fatigue for the players. I have a young team that is learning," Gatheru said. He added that finishing will be a key focus after his players squandered five clear-cut chances.

Meanwhile, Mombasa United and Gucha Stars were embroiled in a dispute over an abandoned Division One match at Mbaraki Stadium on Saturday.

Gucha Stars said they arrived at 11 am for a 1 pm kickoff but were denied access. The Kisii-based side said the match had originally been scheduled for Sunday, and they had agreed to Saturday in good faith. "Our logistical plans, including travel bookings, were aligned with this timeline. It was surprising that the home side, despite rescheduling us, did not know there was another Division One match at the stadium," Gucha Stars said.

Mombasa United, however, accused Gucha Stars of unprofessional conduct, stating that the kickoff had been moved to 3 pm during a joint pre-match meeting with FKF officials. "Mombasa Stars and match officials were ready for kick-off, but after 45 minutes, the game was declared abandoned in line with FKF rules," the club said.

FOOTBALL

Police Bullets stop Trinity's unbeaten run

BY CHARLENE MALWA

League leaders Trinity Starlets saw their unbeaten run end dramatically as defending champions Police Bullets ran riot in theWomen's Premier League on Sunday.

The result served as a wake-up call for Trinity ahead of the festive break. Trinity arrived at the clash top of the table, buoyed by a 1–0 win over Ulinzi Starlets the previous weekend.

Their discipline and structured gameplay had made them formidable this season. However, Police Bullets, themselves in fine form after emphatic wins including 6–0 over Gideon Starlets and 4–0 against Bungoma Queens, dismantled Trinity's system with clinical efficiency.

The match was effectively decided inside the first half-hour. Lorna Nyabuto opened the scoring in just the second minute and doubled her tally in the 14th.

Emily Morang'a headed in a third two minutes later. Puren Alukwe added another in the 26th minute, followed by Maggy's strike on the half-hour mark, leaving Trinity chasing the game far earlier than planned.

Police continued their dominance after the break.

Alukwe completed her brace in the 51st minute, with Morang'a following a minute later. Diana Wacera sealed the rout in the 67th minute, marking her eighth goal of the season and underlining Police's depth and attacking prowess.

Trinity head coach Silvanus Wesonga admitted the opening phase was decisive.

"We have been consistent all season, but today we were punished for our mistakes," he said.

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